The Early Years of Entrapta Phyllipina

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Entrapta (She-Ra), Original Characters, Original Female Character: Dr. Alyndrah Nulvis

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The Early Years of Entrapta Phyllipina

by Kridxen

Summary

A story rebooting the character of Entrapta for a grittier, darker world. Establishing the character so that I can tell another story featuring her.
Through a series of episodes spanning several years, we witness the coming-of-age journey where Entrapta navigates the treacherous landscape of power and politics. With each passing year, she grapples with her identity and her place in a world where survival often means sacrificing one's ideals.
As she grows, Entrapta forms a deep bond with a trusted friend, finding solace in their companionship amidst the chaos. However, as the oppressive regime tightens its grip on Darkland, Entrapta is forced to confront the harsh realities of her existence and the choices she must make to survive.
Amidst the turmoil and uncertainty, Entrapta faces a pivotal decision that will shape the course of her destiny. Will she succumb to the darkness that surrounds her, or will she rise above it to become the beacon of hope her people desperately need?

3/4/2026 - Marked for revision after LLL is complete. Change log to be added at the end of the story.

Chapter 1: Age 10

Chapter Summary

After having a typical childhood in Dryl, Entrapta is introduced to a hard lesson about her station as princess of Dryl.

Suggested music is over here 🙄 (Not every chapter has this.)

Spacy sci fi music calm

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gCWaRhNUvfc

Age 10

"It's Hot!!" The girl shouted, dropping the chunk of iridescent rock. Her hand clutched the other tightly, sweat rising on her brow. She looked over to her father trying to read his expression on how to feel about it. All the while her father just watched, with a small smile on his neatly bearded face. Entrapta looked back to her damage and flexed her little fingers testing out how it moved now. After a moment she decided that it wasn't that bad and grasped for some tongs to recover the rock now on the floor. She plucked the two electrodes from the item and it retreated from its red-hot state.

King Nyland watched his daughter start working on the project again. Part of him wanted to move to care for her but a greater part held him back. He looked to his wife who was having an even more difficult time staying in her chair. His hand came to Lysandra's keeping her from action.

They sat as part of the assembly of parents. Their decree had changed the parameters from the professors at Dryl academy from moving from booth to booth to having each person present their ideas on stage. This would better set Entrapta up for speaking to people. Still, it was troubling to see her literally drop the ball.

Entrapta cleared her throat while murmurs rumbled through the people, "As you can see, the ahm… The vindanyte increases in temperature since it has no other form of release."

She moved over to the next stage, a device that resembled a copper cage, "But if we provide it a channel to dispense its energies…" Entrapta let the chunk of metal go and it clamored to a stop at the bottom for a few moments. The energy surged into the webbing causing a negative charge against its positive one causing the object to rise up to the middle of the cube. Energy crackled along its surface until it reached overload resulting in a series of three arcs that discharged violently but harmlessly into the plate at the bottom three times snapping loudly each time. The box then burst open sending the fragment clattering to the side.

Entrapta's face was a big, mostly toothed smile proud of the results of the demonstration. It slowly fell when no applause came from the audience, only the pleasant muted smiles while the judges turned to their folders at the table nearby and scribbled their findings about the presentation. She waited for the results, still smiling. Finally what made her move was when one of the judges rose from their chair and came over to tell her that she should vacate the stage for the second project presentation.

"Oh… I don't get to know how I did?" the purple haired girl asked.

The panel judge replied politely, "Results will be posted at the end of the day, thank you."

Later…

It wasn’t right. She looked piercingly at the list. "Third?" Entrapta asked her mom, "How can I get third? I had the best experiment!"

Her mother smiled proudly at her, "Yep, that’s okay. Not everyone likes working with vindanyte, plus I think they liked Tryshe’s take on it better than what you came up with. She actually used it to increase the temperature of water. Doing that shows off more of its potential as a power source. The judges must have liked that more."

Entrapta ran her thumb along the silk of the ribbon with the big number 3 on it. It felt deeper than simply her pride being hurt.

Entrapta said, "But, I was supposed to get first."

Lysandra put her hands on her daughter’s shoulders then, "Hey, you were competing with some major contenders at Techno Expo, there wasn’t an age limit so you were up against big kids that wanted scholarships. You’ll do even better next year."

Entrapta complained, "But I don’t want a scholarship, I was supposed to come in first!"

Her mother raised her brows, "Now how would that look? We supplied the grounds and the funding for the expo this year. What if our daughter also won that competition?"

The girl's red-eyed gaze came to bear on her mother, "Is this a lesson then? That you and Dad are going to do things to make it impossible for me to win?"

Her mother consoled, "Not, exactly. You are different from lots of other people, Entrapta. You’re in a position of power and while that makes some things easy for you, some things are going to be very very difficult."

Lysandra's words hung in the air, and Entrapta's frustration simmered beneath the surface. She understood the complexities

that came with her position as a princess, but the bitterness of defeat still lingered. Her experiment with vindanyte, her passion, had been dismissed, and she couldn't shake the feeling of injustice.

Entrapta's eyes narrowed, "I don't like it. I don't like any of it. I should have won because that's what's right. It's what should have happened."

The queen tightened her lips realizing that the lesson was slipping away, "I'm sorry, Entrapta, we should have let you know about the situation before you entered the contest. But, if you knew that it wasn't possible to win, would you have tried that hard?"

The girl's nose scrunched in a sneer glumly admitting, "No…"

Entrapta's frustration lingered, but a flicker of understanding crossed her face. The lesson, though difficult, was sinking in. The queen placed a gentle hand on her daughter's shoulder, "You're destined for greatness, my dear. But greatness often comes from how we handle setbacks and navigate the unexpected. This experience will shape you in ways winning never could."

Entrapta watched the red on the ribbon. The words made sense, there was more to learn in failure than it was to succeed in everything. The haunting thought clung to her though. She felt it in her bones, something was different.

Chapter 2: Age 13

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta talks with her father over breakfast about what's happening to Darkland

Entrapta held the tablet out to her father, "What's a dictator?" She asked.

Nyland pitched his head down slightly, taking the tablet from his daughter's grasp to inspect. Yesterday's article about the Darkland election rolled along the screen showing an overwhelming majority favoring the referendum to allow the military to run the country. A grim, pale faced humanoid raised a hand to the shouts and cheers of people in an enormous crowd. His triangular red eyes squined slightly at the end of the loop.

Entrapta tilted her head at her father asking again, "Are we dictators? We don't hold elections, our edicts are law, we control every aspect of the government. Doesn't that make us dictators?"

Nyland set the device down on the breakfast table, "Well, I wasn't expecting to get into a philosophical debate so soon today. But when I was given the title of king, it was after much deliberation on the last board of directors. Since all the other territories surrounding Dryl held monarchs, it was decided that we should experiment with the form of government as well. Dictators, by contrast, manipulate their way into power."

Entrapta recovered her tablet looking at her father with scrutiny, "And you did -nothing- to favor yourself as the one that should be chosen for the job."

The king nodded confidently at her, "Nobody was more surprised than me when the vote came in. I accepted it on the condition that I would give up my power when my first born child would

come of age and we would have the chance to re-evaluate their decision. I wanted to be a good monarch, so I did not dissolve the board that granted me power, rather one of my first actions was to make sure that should something happen to me, they would have all the means to reinstitute the corporatocracy."

Entrpata casually studied the tablet by clicking the 'down' button a few times to browse, "So… what are your findings?"

Nyland settled down in a chair nearby. He looked at his hands, considering his daughter's question. "Well, it's been a mix of successes and challenges. The stability provided by a monarchy has kept Dryl relatively secure, especially when dealing with external threats. However, the experiment has also revealed the limitations of a single ruling entity in adapting to the changing needs and perspectives of the people."

Entrapta nodded, absorbing the information. "And how do you plan to approach the upcoming re-evaluation when I come of age?"

The king smiled, "I believe in transparency and open dialogue. The people of Dryl should have a say in their governance. We'll assess the effectiveness of the monarchy and explore alternative systems, ensuring that whatever decision we make aligns with the best interests of our citizens."

Entrapta's eyes lit up with curiosity. "And what if the people decide to maintain the monarchy? Will you continue to rule?"

Nyland chuckled, entertaining that thought for a moment, "That would be their choice, and I would honor it. However, it's also an opportunity for us to consider how the monarchy can evolve to better serve the needs of the realm. Change, when necessary, should be embraced, and I hope you'll be part of that process."

Entrapta frowned thoughtfully, rolling more information from the tablet to absorb.

Nyland’s mouth twitched to one side seeing Entrpata starting to drift back into the network. He decided to confess what he knew about the re-evaluation, "They’re going to be evaluating *you* , Entrapta.” His abrupt words made her look up from the scrolling she was doing. Her father continued, “The board of directors is going to ask you questions. About what, I’m not sure exactly, but I know that you’re going to be speaking on behalf of your generation and what their experience has been throughout my reign."

Entrapta’s mind reeled with shock, so many things started to fall into place. Her experiences with the Techno Expo, the special tutors brought in from other kingdoms, being forced to visit worksites, school visits, the ‘special reports’ that she was tasked with, the many times that he brought her to court, it was all building up to this. She flushed slightly, starting to feel guilty about complaining about the many ‘field trips’ that she was forced to go on.

Nyland watched the realization dawn on Entrapta's face. He reached across the table, placing a hand on hers. "You're more than capable, Entrapta. You've shown incredible intelligence and innovation. This isn't a test to judge you but an opportunity for your generation to shape the future of Dryl. Your voice matters."

Entrapta stared at her father, a mix of emotions playing on her features. "But what if they don't like what I say? What if they decide something that I don't agree with?”

Nyland squeezed her hand reassuringly. “Entrapta, we need to follow what they say. Before you were born, people were tense about the notion of letting businesses that had monopolies on our resources also decide how we live as a whole. The people looked to the surrounding monarchies as something to aspire to be since they held their borders in relative harmony with each other.”

He looked at the tablet in Entrapta’s other hand, tightening his features, “This… thing that Darkland has done, greatly concerns me. It will be a great test upon our neighbors. Us as well.”

Entrapta took a deep breath, feeling the weight of responsibility settling on her shoulders. “I'll do my best, Dad. I just want what's best for Dryl.”

Her father smiled, proud of the young woman she was becoming. “And that, Entrapta, is exactly why you'll be great in this role. Just be true to yourself and speak from the heart.”

Chapter 3: Age 15

Chapter Summary

Entrapta bears witness to a trial. She sees that the board of directors still holds judicial power over the people.

Nyland and Lysandra talk about what the future might hold for Dryl.

(Dark ambient music by Eternal Dystopia, Youtube playlist)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2mcGhpbWlyg&list=UULPJUPRD_SneWvoKaMBIUNiFg

It was a day of mixed emotions in Dryl. The sun hung low in the sky, casting long shadows over the kingdom. The public square was abuzz with people going about their daily lives, and in the midst of it all, a peculiar trial was taking place.

Entrapta, now fifteen, observed from the royal balcony. The accused stood in the center of the square, surrounded by a makeshift courtroom.

The judge, Orion Starwatcher, Head of CelystialStone Observatory, wore an expression that mixed weariness with determination.

"They can't sell processors, sir!" the first man shouted, "Especially if they're going to be called Hako processors, My processors are called Heko processors, it's only a letter different!"

The other man shouted back, "I suppose that means that we can't have 'Insight Binoculars' shop across the way because they sound like in-sight binoculars and the two have been there for twenty years!"

"I spent years perfecting the Hako processor! Your shoddy work is not only of poor quality but it's bringing down the reputation

that I worked so hard to make! Justice! I need Justice!" the first mat shrieked.

Spittle shot from the second man's mouth, "You're just upset that it was so easy to make a similar chip that is ready to make yours obsolete with the enhancements I've made to the cooling system!"

Orion rubbed at his face while they shot back and forth over-shouting each other. Crowd voices started to rise up becoming more and more heated as the people began to side with one another. Panic started to creep into Orion's expression quickly realizing that he needed to do something before things started to become physical. He started to shout something but there was no chance that he could be heard over the growing circus. He leaned over to his bodyguard and pointed at the crowd. The burly woman stood up on a table drawing her weapon, pointing it at the sky. The triple burst fire was the noise that made the crowd quiet down.

Orion's voice was small then, it didn't have to be loud anymore. Entrapta strained from the balcony to understand what was being said. The first man made a shout but was quickly silenced when the bodyguard hopped off Orion's table and shouted something at him with a point.

Entrapta's knuckles whited on the balcony when the crowd started to rise up again but the firearm was waved in the sky with threatening shouts. Orion's voice was quiet again. Whatever he said made the crowd settle down. The two defendants proceeded to make rude gestures at one another. They almost took steps towards one another but the bodyguard moved between them and shouted loudly that the verdict had been made. Somewhere behind them the crowd was still unsatisfied, a chunk of thick cardboard came sailing over their heads landing squarely against the guard's temple laying her out. Entrapta gasped and just like that, Courtly Commons Square was chaos, people screamed as they started to tear at each other. The burst of noise roused the ten or so gate guards and they began to wade into the crowd

separating people. Entrapta could bear no more and backed away from the balcony. She could hear the royal captain's mechanical shouts from far away begin issuing separation orders. She bolted out of her room realizing that order needed to be restored to the people. Just before she left the living quarters of the castle her mother caught sight of her running and grabbed her shoulder.

"Where are you going in such a hurry?" asked Lysandra.

"They're brawling!" Entrapta said, "If I don't go out there, there are going to be casualties!"

Before she could say anything else the sudden sound of gunfire popped from the distant outside. A swell of primal screams followed shortly after. The queen's eyes flashed wide and held Entrapta protectively, "Absolutely not! We need to make sure that we are safe. Let's get deeper into the castle!"

Entrapta wrung herself out of her mother's grasp. Retreat was the exact opposite of what was on her mind, "You can hide in here, but I need to make sure that the situation is handled!"

Lysandra only needed to look for a moment at Entrapta's resolute expression. She knew what her husband would say, with a breath and a terribly heartbroken expression on her face she turned from her daughter and started doing what her mind told her needed to happen.

Entrapta just stood there, further automatic gunfire tapped through the air. She was ready to fight her mom further but without her here to argue with, she could only wrestle with her own thoughts. Her red gaze turned over to the entryway that would take her outside only a short run away from the conflict. Her mother had turned the corner now. When she looked back to the exit, the four walls there seemed to rise taller and taller. When more gunfire tapped out, a shiver struck her, thinking through the physics involved in gunfire, cold numbers simply displaying force, impact, exit wounds…

Entrapta took one step back, then another from the exit, turned and hurried after where her mother retreated.

It was weeks before they were allowed to leave the palace. Nyland stayed in the office for hours late into the night issuing several edicts restricting firearm discharge.

The king stared over folded fingers at the papers before him. He lamented, "We've never had gunfire in the square before. Never during arbitration…"

Lysandra came over to where his dark features flickered in the candle light to hold him from behind, "There were no deaths at least."

Nyland held his wife's hand against his chest, "But the people are restless. They've been circulating Horde propaganda amongst themselves. If I hear 'Technology, for a purpose' one more time, I'm going to scream."

The man tried to laugh it away but it came out sardonic.

His wife said, "He's manipulated his people, we will *never* do that. He's seriously pitching to them that an entire alien civilization is coming, ships that will fill the sky. The whole notion is ridiculous."

Nylan shook his head, "They say that *he* is such an alien."

She shook her head, "Does he look so different from a Scorponi? Or simply a shape shifter that settled on that look?"

His brow creased, "Well, when you put it like that…"

They stayed like that for a long moment, the engines of Dryl quietly droning along.

Nylan finally said, "He scares me, no matter what he is. He's wielded the Darkland people into something fanatical, dangerous,

angry. I don’t think any of our kingdoms have ever had to deal with a threat like this before.”

Quiet thunder echoed off the city walls promising rain soon. Lysandra slipped her hand back to herself, “I’m going to sleep, he won’t take over tonight. It can wait.”

Chapter 4: Age 18

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta has the opportunity to present a project that she's been working on to the Dryl board of directors. Much of what they do is hear proposals that they then have the option of supporting or denying funding for, much like Dragon's Den / Shark Tank.

Blade runner style ambient music mix

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eFpIhv2ggXM&t=5778s

The board of directors shuffled the folders over each other looking at the statistics that were held within. More than one eyebrow became raised looking at some of the claims being made on the charts.

Entrapta stood before them, young features drawn into a-matter-of-fact expression. She waited patiently unafraid in the slightest.

She wielded the disgruntled attention easily, "You're perturbed at the papers already. Good."

Entrapta commanded, "Open to the first page if you're not there already or were unable to help yourself from reading ahead." She pressed a button on the table in front of her, the screen lighting her up in silhouette. "Observe the video if you will."

She proceeded to organize the next bundle of papers that she intended on handing out while a video of a person in Dryl special ops clothing ran through an obstacle course. The woman in combat fatigues moved through a hallway and crouched down rolling a small ball to where the hallway turned 90 degrees. The angle cut from the original view to the feed from the ball. A target dummy was positioned in the hallway and a separate screen rolled the calculations being uploaded. From the crouch

the soldier fired tracer rounds that arced, impossibly navigating the corner and impacted the target knocking it to the ground.

Entrapta began passing out the next document to them, "Asymmetry Pyroarc weapons promise to bring a new dimension to warfare. Let's delve into the key features of our innovation. The Pyroarc Weapons utilize a smart bullet technology that incorporates advanced algorithms and real-time data analysis. These bullets are designed to navigate obstacles, making them ideal for urban combat scenarios and situations where conventional ammunition might be ineffective."

Entrapta pushed the button on the table again, another slide replaced the ending of the video showing off the incredible axis that a bullet is able to travel, "The bullets can make three mid-course corrections without losing lethal kinetic energy unassisted. If necessary, an advanced A.I. program in the gun can be turned on and decides if it can use existing materials in the walls to ricochet up to two additional times in flight path to reach the target. The accuracy of this program is an acceptable 80 percent hit rate with zero friendly targets hit in testing. Obviously this allows our forces to take advances on the enemy while remaining in complete cover.

Entrapta gestured to an aide who started to hand out a third packet of documents to the board members. "What is being passed around is more technical specifications to read at your leisure. Notably, these weapons are not only a huge step in defensive offense, we are able to unload a majority of the weight into the bullets themselves as they are self propelling. We have gone through the proper channels of open field testing as well as urban environments and the Pyroarc weaponry has excelled well beyond conventional ballistics. We've had to redefine a few of the tests just to capture some of the new statistics. Our accuracy can get between millimeters when pointed unobstructed at a target whereas the old measures were done in ten-centimeter increments.

She pushed the button again and the slide moved to the next statistics outpouring.

Entrapta said casually, "I can bore you with the exact statistics that go into the increased firepower, suffice to say that we estimate that Pyroarc rifles place themselves somewhere between twice to three times more effective in combat than conventional ballistics. This means more soldiers coming home to their families which is what advanced weapons are all about."

Entrpata advanced the presentation to the last slide showing off several tags indicating the classified nature of the project.

She explained, "Obviously many aspects of the program are classified. You won't find anything in the booklets about how the A.I. was developed, what goes into the programming in the bullets, or what materials were used in the gun casings. All of this was done to ensure that Dryl has their 'Ace in the hole' so to speak. It is my intention and requirement that this be deployed *only* to select agents and only to a select few guard captains. Each firearm has a timeout that detonates all bullets inside should it not have contacts with a carrier frequency on the network that we are calling 'code: Entrapt-net'. What I *can* tell you is that it requires a fiber optic processor to properly decrypt the pass-key to keep the gun running at a predetermined interval. If it ever gets too far away from the network or we designate that firearm compromised… well we won't need any recon teams to recover the device."

Entrapta gestured to her aid who in turn raised the lights back to a comfortable level.

The purple-haired engineer raised her eyebrows, commenting, "I can take a few questions now, keep in mind much of the project remains classified for good reason."

Orion, head of Celestial Stones Observatory was first to speak, "Did you say that an A.I. was going to be controlling the guns?

What kind of decisions is it capable of making? Can it decide not to fire?"

Entrapta shakes her head, "The A.I. is limited to interpreting data from an onboard X-ray/Sonar combination to make best use of trajectories. It might be a little bit generous to call it a full A.I. like Emily is. It's just very good at deciding which directions to send the bullets. It's also worth mentioning that due to the ultra high refresh rate, there is only anywhere between fifty to three hundred chances to interrupt the bullet's flight. Bullets are very fast."

Orion sputtered, "' *Full'* A.I.? You've managed to create an adaptable learning program?"

Entrapta winced at the outburst, "I'm… not really prepared to talk about Emily. This is a meeting in regards to Pyroarc Firearms."

"I have a question." Evelyn Raydiant spoke up. She was head of the Ether Energy, the corporation that oversaw the geothermal power that ran most of Dryl, "The bottom line states that the weapon is thirty thousand dollars to produce. Who exactly is going to be *paying* for this? *How many* have you made?"

It made Entrapta scowl, returning to the confident voice she had up until Orion threw her off, "I'm *sorry* I thought that this council was entertaining the idea of entering into a weapons contract with the Horde at some point in the near future. If we do that, we need to have something that can completely outmaneuver what we output from our factories. Otherwise, we're arming our neighbor for an obvious invasion!"

Evelyn shook her head, "What you're proposing here, even on a small scale is insane. Iron clad contracts and agreements are what we should be focusing on, not bankrupting our people just to make sure that we can out-shoot what we put out there."

Entrapta shook her head, "Hordak manipulates the things that he comes in contact with. He's convinced his entire people that there

is a threat that doesn't exist. He's pinned a whole nation on a trite phrase that is easy to regurgitate instead of thinking." Entrapta patted the table earnestly, " *This* ensures our safety. It keeps us a power not to be trifled with. With council approval we can begin a factory line building enough of these to arm all of our special ops. A full factory line will make the price of production considerably lower. The days of swelling battles on mass scale are over, they went away when automatic ballistics were invented. The next battle we fight will be of unity, only a few will need to be enforcers."

Evelyn just shook her head back and slid the folder away from herself, "I'm not backing this. Even generously bringing the cost down by fifty percent is still a fifteen thousand dollars. Even if there are three of these guns, it's already over-budget, even for a prototype."

Isabella was the next head of ZephyrTech Airships. She simply echoed Evelyn's gesture pushing the folder away from herself.

Orion and the other six held on to their folders. He closed the binder and looked up to Entrapta, "The work that went into this is very impressive, Entrapta. I want to read more before I make any decisions. I mean… if you have the ability to manufacture an A.I., why not monetize and build that out? It's strange, all the pieces of this are interesting but what they're being used for…"

The other board members didn't have anything else to contribute, they just looked to each other.

Finally after a few beats Entrapta settled her shoulders, cleared her throat and said, "Then, I look forward to hearing your conclusions on the proposed line."

Chapter 5: Age 20

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta displays her engineering prowess by creating a 'toolbot' that she'd like to test out in her dad's divested company.

Melodic quiet ambience

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=acT1W6vTUHQ

She looked intensely at the metal box. Three red lights triangulated how far away the damaged wire was. The little tank treads appeared to struggle moving along the polished surface of the desk. Her slender fingers gripped at the table wanting to help it in the task but if she did, it would never learn. She had to wait. It moved close… closer. The mechanisms inside decided to flap open the onboard soldering equipment to heat up. She covered her mouth knowing that this was a huge success even on its own, she knew it's calculated how long it's going to take to get to the problem and to work on the solution. It must have been uploading its time table now to Emily.

Entrapta silently mouthed through her fingers, 'come on…' hoping against hope that it finally would succeed fully. Though it was agonizingly slow, it did make it to the frayed cable and brought the hot solder iron to the problem. A puff of smoke and a scoot back is all it took in the end and its red lights switched to green. It whirled around and headed back to its base on the other side of the desk backing into it.

Entrapta leapt up from the desk hooting and clapping. She pointed at the bot and shouted at Orion, "Did you see that? Did you fucking see that!?"

The man's jaw was slack, "I…" is all he stammered out before Entrapta gushed, "It had *never* encountered that before and it still

deduced the fix! It didn't even need to link up to Emily!" She scooped up the box and gave it a happy smooch, "You did *so good* Toolbot 725!"

Orion nodded, "It is truly impressive that it is able to problem solve without needing the network A.I.. When are you going to propose this to the board?"

"The board?" Entrapta echoed, much of her mood dropping, "After they shuttered Pyroarc? Why the hell would I want to show them something like this? It certainly isn't cost effective, we have people going to school wanting to be a part of their industries. Honestly I think the people would be irritated or even hostile towards something like this… and since the board are also representatives of the people of Dryl they'd probably just shut it down."

He shook his head, "I hardly think that. When they retired project Pyroarc, they mentioned that they want to continue to hear further proposals from you and your team, Entrapta. They don't do that for just anyone."

Entrpata set the bot down, looking evenly at him, "Look, All I need from Evelyn is a formal apology about Pyroarc. If she can't bring herself to that then she needs to drop these 'Darkland contract invitation' proposals to the council. I am going to insist Dad vetoes each time because it's completely stupid to give a dictator firearms that can immediately be used against us. Not without having superior firepower to retaliate."

Orion steepled his fingers in thought. Entrapta settled back down into her chair considering what he might be thinking about. She decided to change the subject, "You know, you're the only one on the board of directors I'm still talking to. I think we both see it for what it is, just a bunch of corporations that have banded together and quietly seethe that they have to be responsible for the public due to the constitution of Dryl."

Orion chortled quoting the document, "When a corporation becomes consistently ten percent or more of the GDP for ten years, it is to be indoctrinated into the board of directors and its mission statement must then include 'shall do no harm to the people and instead now work for the benefit of society instead of profit.'"

Entrpata gave a dry laugh, "The ultimate want of any capitalist, no more profit and instead become part of the government." She squinted at him, "Why don't you act like them?"

Orion shook his head, "I'm not my father? I inherited the observatory, never had a problem with serving the people."

Entrapta nodded, the pause after grew stale before she asked, "How are the Chronos assembly lines?"

Orion raised a brow at the question, it was common knowledge that Nyland's factory was divested to a trust and temporarily removed from the council while he was king. "An interesting question coming from you, Princess Entrapta."

Entrapta frowned, "Don't give me that. You know I'm just curious." When his expression didn't change she rolled her eyes, explaining, "I just want a spot to try out the Toolbot in a real world environment."

The man clarified, "You mean that you might let Chronos get exclusive access to this invention first?"

Entrapta threw her arms wide, "I'm *not* saying that at all! I need an environment where they can encounter problems that I haven't thought of for them. A *test!* "

Orion gave her a disarming grin, "Specifically Chronos? Why there? Why not say… LumenTech?"

Entrapta pouted hearing Evelyn's company name, quickly fabricating a believable lie, "LumenTech doesn't have pneumatics,

hydraulics or moving parts on the scale that Chronos does. All it is is a network hub that monitors the geothermal reactors."

Orion replied matter-of-factly, "Ahh so something like ZephyrTech, where they are assembling drones and other airplanes."

Entrapta squinted at him in an accusing way. She then lifted the Toolbot prototype that was no more than a foot by six inches by six inches into the palm of her hand. She then had the other run in front of it as though it was obvious its size disqualified it from working on aircraft.

The sarcastic display made Orion laugh, "Alright, alright, but you're going to have to think about these kinds of questions if you're going to get Nyland's approval to test it out in Chronos."

Entrapta's red eyes widened excitedly, deducing "You mean you'll back my request?"

Orion waved dismissively, "Yes, yes. I think it's very obvious that this is an innovative product that you're putting your mind to. It's honestly much more satisfying than watching you work on guns."

She couldn't help herself, Entrapta nearly tossed the bot to the table and threw her arms around Orion excitedly, "Ohhh you won't regret this! I'm going to go get the other two prototypes ready!"

Orion called after the scampering Entrapta, his voice rose in volume, "I'm only able to back up the request! Nyland has to be the one to approve-!!" He sighed, now alone in the room. "Youth…" he lamented.

Chapter 6: Age 21

Chapter Summary

> In this pivotal chapter, Princess Entrapta faces a critical evaluation by the board of directors of Dryl, defending the monarchy and her leadership potential. Despite intense scrutiny, she remains composed and presents her case for continuity and her role in leading the Chronos machine lines. As the evaluation progresses, tensions rise, and Entrapta grapples with challenging questions about her past actions and qualifications.

Entrapta walked into the special ceremonial hall. She wore a smart grey pants suit, purple tie, padded shoulders. She could hear her flat shoes echo on the marbled flooring as she approached the end of an arcing table that she was to stand in the center of. The top of the table was at shoulder height, the directors each looking down at her as she approached. Each was wearing a ceremonial red cape over their shoulders. A quiet harmonic from somewhere gave the room a long drawn out hallowed note that seemed to last forever. She stepped onto the square bringing her eye to eye with the board of directors looking blankly at her. Well, all of them except for Orion who wore a welcoming smile on his wrinkled face.

Warren, head of PeakStone Mining was first to speak, "We gather here on request of King Nyland of Dryl to evaluate how the current generation of children has been raised in the mighty kingdom of Dryl. Princess Entrapta is to be awarded the honor of answering for the generation started twenty one years ago since she has the best opportunities of all the children. We, the board of directors, shall be allotted time to probe and then shall evaluate if the monarchy shall continue to another generation or if the experiment is to be concluded and the prior establishment of corporatocracy shall be reinstated. Do you have anything to say in your opening statements, Nyland?"

Nearby, the king rose from reserved seating, "After the unanimous agreement to establish a monarchy, I was humbled and very aware of what was set at my feet. I had to trust in the adage that those best suited to lead do not ask themselves but are instead asked. I sought to ensure the future of this great land based on fairness and rationale. I ask that you fairly evaluate the greatest achievement of my life, my daughter Entrapta. I am no perfect parent, but I know that I have instilled in her the right lessons to make a kind, just, and fair ruler of our people. I recognized our old system's resilience and wanted the opportunity to return to it if this trust placed in me fell to another adage: absolute power corrupts absolutely." Some of the board members chuckled at the seeming absurdity, considering Nyland's history as a very capable king

He then took the opportunity to give his daughter one final push, "It brings my heart such joy to be here today, I am so very proud of you, Entrapta."

Entrapta's cheeks flushed with his parental compliment.

Warren's lips smiled with Nyland's speech, but when he looked back to his documents he returned to the professional expression he had before, "Very good, Nyland, we've always been impressed by you and thank you for your wisdom to hold this evaluation here and now. Let us proceed to the evaluation, Entrapta you have your opening statement and what your desires are here before the council."

Entrapta felt the moisture leave her throat, she had been preparing literally her whole life for this moment. She cleared her voice verberating back to her from the halls. Entrapta forced a confident stand, her gaze unwavering despite the scrutiny from the board of directors. She took a deep breath, her voice clear and steady as she began her opening statement.

"Ladies and gentlemen of the board, esteemed guests, my dear father, King Nyland and my treasured Mother, Queen Lysandra. I stand before you today not just as a princess but as a product of

the values instilled in me by my parents and the kingdom of Dryl. I am honored to address you on this crucial occasion and express my unwavering commitment to the monarchy.

“Firstly, let me make it unequivocally clear that I cherish the monarchy and believe in its ability to provide stability, continuity, and a connection to our storied past. My desire is to see my parents, King Nyland and Queen Lysandra, maintain their rightful positions until they naturally pass. Their wisdom and guidance have been the bedrock of our kingdom, and I am proud to be their daughter.”

“Furthermore, I wish to contribute to the prosperity of Dryl in a meaningful way. I have spent years honing my skills, earning degrees in engineering and technology, and gaining hands-on experience. It is my hope today that the Chronos machine lines are to be reinstated on the board of directors with me at the head. I promise to bring innovation and efficiency to our industrial sector. The trust placed in me by my father, as well as the education and experiences I've accumulated, have prepared me for this responsibility.”

More than one of the board members murmured to themselves hearing Entrapta’s wishes about Chronos.

“I hold degrees in mechanical engineering, advanced robotics, and industrial management, and have successfully managed various projects during my developing years. My goal is to apply this knowledge and expertise to ensure that Chronos becomes a beacon of technological advancement, driving Dryl into a prosperous future.”

“In conclusion, I stand before you not just as a princess, but as a capable and dedicated individual with a genuine love for Dryl. I urge you to consider the potential for progress and unity that maintaining the monarchy and entrusting me with the Chronos machine lines can bring. Together, we can secure a future that upholds our traditions while embracing the promise of innovation and prosperity."

Entrapta listened to the harmonic drone eclipse the silence that followed her statement.

Warren was the first to speak, “An interesting proposal in regards to Chronos. You are well aware that your father’s company was purposefully divested so that there would be no conflict of interest when it came to his power and the company.”

Entrapta nodded, “I am aware of that.”

Warren said, “So you are then aware that you would not have the same kind of contact with your family should we approve this request to have you head Chronos.”

Entrapta’s red eyes looked over to Nyland, a sad smile tugged at her lips, “I’m aware. I would represent the people in another way. I would have only casual interaction with the monarchy.” She looked back to Warren, “I propose that should my parents pass, I would ascend to queen of Dryl and of course divest Chronos again to another board member or third party at that time.”

Warren nodded and wrote on a paper in front of him. Silence gripped them a long moment and finally he asked, “Can you clarify what you mean by 'casual interaction'? How would you navigate potential challenges in balancing your role as a member of the royal family and a leader within Chronos?”

She shook her head slightly, “Well… business is business and family is family. Anything that happens on the Chronos campus would be my main focus, but I still want to occasionally interact with my parents… they’re my parents.”

Warren gave a thoughtful nod, following up with, “You've highlighted your commitment to representing the people. How do you plan to demonstrate this commitment through your leadership at Chronos? What initiatives or policies do you envision that would directly benefit the citizens of Dryl?

She let a smile through at that question, “I have several projects lined up, all of which have great potential to radically improve efficiencies as well as some innovative products that will improve quality of life for the people of Dryl.”

He nodded again, “I look forward to more specifics in regards to those projects, Princess Entrapta. No further questions.” He gestured to his left.

Austyn Verdant, head of AeroFlora Agricultural Industries was next in line, a dashing fellow, young and in a suit behind the ceremonial cape. A smirk came to his face. He spoke with a twang, “Just got the one question and Warren even led up to it. What are your loyalties to Dryl?”

Entrapta winced, “I’m not sure I understand the question?”

He clarified, “I’m just wonderin’ if you answer to the people or if the people answer to you?”

Entrapta made a face thinking quickly, “Well, I think that any partnership goes both ways. I vow to take the words of the public to heart and in return I would ask that they follow my word.”

He shrugged, “That’s good enough for me, you’re up madame.”

To his left was Aquylla Torrent, Director of HydroForge Water Management. She gave a kind smile, “I’m afraid I have no real probing questions for you, Entrapta. So long as you promise to keep the water flowing to the people, we should have no conflict. I would trust you to keep things moving with Chronos should we decide to grant you governance over your father’s company.”

Orion was next. Entrapta visibly relaxed knowing that he was one of her only true friends in this room. He asked, “I see here that you graduated from the academy in the top ten percent of the class. Do you think that the instructors there were in any way influenced by your connection to the crown?”

Entrapta shook her head, “The teaching council has had no contact with Nyland or the monarchy to the best of my knowledge other than update reports of my grades.”

Orion nodded, “It appears that you were also allowed several presentations to this board of directors, an honor only a few in our kingdom get a single chance at. While only Toolbot program was approved and the other three rejected, what are your thoughts on these experiences?”

She was taken aback by the question. She cleared her throat, stammering, “I… ahm…” Her eyes darted briefly to Evelyn, then to Orion, “It’s… taught me… conflict management and…”

She closed her eyes, taking a breath, “Not every idea gets through on the first try. I have the Pyroarc initiative in lower proceedings looking for funding from other sources.”

Evelyn visibly sneered at the mention of the project.

Entrapta continued, “I am also big enough to admit a mistake, I wasn’t fully prepared to present Project Hemodyne and the council was right in turning it down because of that.”

Orion gave a nod, a smile rising to his face, “Thank you, Entrapta. I appreciate your honesty with these answers.” He gestured to his left indicating he was done. The princess scrunched her brow, surprised at her friend’s brevity on his questions. She thought for sure Orion might delve into what exactly went into her schooling, how hard the degrees were to achieve that she’s obtained, but he truly was done already, looking back to his notes before him. Perhaps she was stalling because she knew who was next. Entrapta felt her lower lids tighten, it was Evelyn’s turn to interview her.

“I see here” Papers shuffled, “That you placed… third? In the Techno Expo?”

Entrapta blinked, the question completely hobbled her, “I… suppose?”

“Third place.” Evelyn repeated, “Your father had special tutors come to train you specifically and the best that you could manage is third place.”

Her mouth parted open, a disgusted look almost rising to her face as the ancient ire was stoked, yes she *should* have gotten first but she shook her head, “That was… so long ago, Evelyn.”

Evelyn nodded, “I suppose it was, but we *are* here to evaluate how you’ve grown into adulthood under Nyland’s Dryl. You were given the best opportunities and the best of our people so when we start out here at third, it does draw a little concern.”

She looked over her papers, “The insurrection at Courtly Commons square, you were seen at the balcony during the instigating argument. What happened after that?”

Her lips thinned, disliking the leading question, “When the tensions escalated I had every intention of coming to the aid of Orion. When I heard gunfire in the square I… re-evaluated-”

Evelyn knifed in, “You retreated deeper into the palace, letting the brave guards stand in danger for your safety.”

Entrapta’s voice edged anger, “My priority was to ensure my own safety to better contribute to resolving the conflict afterward, not to mention the potential impact on innocent lives. Survival is sometimes the only strategic move in a chaotic scenario.”

They stared at each other, quiet tension mounted as the drone filled the room again. Evelyn was first to speak, “Final question: What code of ethics do you plan to follow should you ascend to the throne after your parents pass away?”

It took every effort she had to not roll her eyes at the impossible question. After a moment of thought Entrapta replied, “I plan on studying the history of our people for answers on difficult decisions. I will, as my father did, choose to follow the wisdom of the board of directors at every chance I get. I firmly believe that collective wisdom leads to more comprehensive and just choices.”

Evelyn's nose twitched and gestured to her left indicating that she was done.

It was Isabella Skyward next, head of ZephyrTech Airship Manufacturing. She leaned over to an aide and gestured. The aide started passing out papers to the council. Entrapta scrunched her brows again unsure what was happening. Isabella explained, "I'm passing around a formal request that is in the works right now against ZephyrTech. It appears that a drone was discovered crashed on the edge of Horde territory. This drone had an unauthorized flight plan that put it within viewing distance of a Horde testing field while dangerously close to their airspace. As we all know-"

"Excuse me." Entrapta felt sweat roll down her back, "What's… what's all this? Is this part of the evaluation?"

Isabella held the silence a moment, a glare on her face, she began her sentence again "As we all know, the Horde contracts for weaponry has a strict non-interference clause with Dryl. Any aggressive act on our part gives them full permission to escalate." Isabella watched a long moment at the purple haired engineer. "Is there something you want to share with us in regards to this, Princess?"

Entrapta's lips thinned, jaw set firm, "The drone never entered the airspace. The plan was to observe and confirm or discredit information collected that the Horde was working on their own version of Pyroarc."

Isabella slowly nodded letting the situation hang in the room. Voices of the witnesses and other board members started to quietly murmur until Warren gave his gavel a quiet clack. She said, "I'm sure if I was to ask the Arms and Armor council about this, they would tell me that the flight plan was unauthorized because it is classified in nature."

She stared at the woman with her red eyes, her tone even and firm, hoping that the honest answer would suffice, "And you

would be correct in that assumption."

Isabella's face was plain, nodding and writing. She took a sharp breath and asked, "Are there any other classified projects that you're working with the Arms and Armor council?"

"Only Pyroarc." she hesitated only a moment, "I have been offered two problems to take on but I am not at liberty to talk about their status."

Isabella's brows rose as she wrote more and mentioned, "Our princess has secrets." She gestured to her left.

Entrapta turned to face the next person… only two more rakes over the coals to go…

Later…

In the antechamber was just outside the ceremonial meeting room Entrapta sat with her parents. The engineer's legs bounced on the balls of her feet nervously. She looked over to the narrow vertical windows. They were framed by dark drapes that had angled pattern designs woven into them. The windows looked out over the geometric city of Dryl. Seams of the concrete slabs that made up the room worked to outline some designs depicting Dryl's history that were etched into them. The light from the windows created sharp shadows on the carvings in the walls. The couch she sat on was grey and white. It sat atop dark grey, low, durable carpeting. A solid white coffee table had a cluster of paper water cups and a few thin books.

She struggled with the collar of her shirt fighting with the clip-on tie. She hated dressing up. Entrapta got up from her seat again, trekking over to the water dispenser for the fifth time. Nyland held the bridge of his nose. Entrapta could tell that her father was replaying the interview, trying to figure out-

"I don’t *know* how they learned about the crashed drone so fast!! It only went down last week and it was supposed to be a black ops!" Entrapta shouted. She whipped around to see her dad unsettled by the volume of her voice, clearly they weren’t on the same page. Entrapta threw the new paper cup harmlessly across the room hitting the wall in a burst. "The last questions were not even fair! How was I supposed to know all those differentials of input to output in the mines! How was I supposed to know how much foot-traffic went through the palace on a given day!"

The king and queen exchanged uncertain glances, grappling with how to address the escalating outburst. Lysandra tentatively suggested, "Maybe you should sit down-" but before she could finish, Entrapta exploded, “Are you two in on this? Is this another chance for my *development?”*

Lysandra rose then drawing a proverbial line, "That’s not fair Entrapta. Your father and I have been doing everything we can within reason to make you prepared for this day."

Entrapta fired back, "We’re not living within a time of *reason* , Mom! The horde is knocking at our door and the fact that the people are even considering moving from a decisive form of government like a monarchy to something that will require deliberation and precious seconds when decisions need to be concise and absolute. It’s going to slog everything down!"

Nyland took a turn at trying to calm Entrapta down, "Our family was privileged to be in this kind of position, Entrapta. We will always be a part of the people, no matter how much power our family wields. We must accept this or run the risk of being viewed as *petulant* ."

His pointed words resonated. Her fury turned to embers and she marched back to her seat on the couch crashing into it loudly with her face in her hands, purple hair falling around her. Her voice croaked, “It’s as if they had already determined the outcome, relishing the spectacle of a mouse realizing its impending doom.”

The king nestled into his chair bringing his hand back to the bridge of his nose, Entrapta understood now that he was only thinking with the pose.

Lysandra risked sitting next to the fuming Entrapta, "Let's take what they said for what it is. They are simply going to consider your original proposal. You were so eloquent and diplomatic in your opening statement. I was so impressed, Entrapta. No matter what they decide, they can't take away the display you made today. Even if it's the end of the Dryl monarchy, I couldn't have dreamed of a better end for it."

Entrapta clung to her mother tightly, weeping softly. Her voice warbled, "I'm so sorry I couldn't do better. They were just so mean! I tried so hard!" She heard her father shift from his chair and felt him sit on the sofa with her and Lysandra. His hand came to her back patting and rubbing to calm her down. The outburst finally passed and she let go, wiping at her face. "I… I hadn't done that in a long time. I'm sorry."

Her mother smiled kindly, holding her shoulders, "You're *never* too old for that."

Almost on cue, a knocking came to the door of the antechamber.

Shortly…

The trio walked from the antechamber back into the imposing room with the drone. Entrapta made sure that her tie was still secure in its hold as she stepped up on the marble block to be at eye level with the board members. Warren was the first to speak again since PeakStone was the longest standing business. "After careful consideration, we, the senior board members of the great kingdom of Dryl have drawn our conclusions. It is our decision that King Nyland should enjoy his continued powers of monarchy, but no such powers shall be bestowed upon his next of kin."

Entrapta trembled, narrowed her lips but prepared to listen further.

Orion cleared his throat and added, “It was our opinion that we should currently have a head of state that is able to make quick decisions in regards to military action should they be needed, but we saw little reason to continue the monarchy in regards to civic problems. We recognize Nyland as a good judge of character and a fine military leader but it isn’t necessary for him to oversee the minutiae of law making.”

Isabella added, “Should Nyland pass, the powers of government shall return to the prior corporatocracy that our forefathers saw fit to govern by. Entrapta shall retain the title of princess without duty to follow. With this in mind, we wish to reinstate the Chronos assembly lines back into the council as suggested by the princess with her as the head of that company. We have slated this transition to happen in the coming few weeks finalizing on September 8th.

Entrapta processed the information, her mind working through the implications. "So, my dad continues for now, and after he's gone, it's the end of monarchy powers. In the meantime, I am becoming the head of Chronos. Is that the deal?"

Warren nodded, "Exactly. We believe this compromise respects the legacy of your father while aligning with the changing needs of Dryl. You will continue to play a crucial role in the kingdom's defense through Chronos."

"I understand," she said, her voice steady despite the swirling thoughts in her mind. "I appreciate the consideration given to my father's legacy and the kingdom's future needs. If this is what the board deems best for Dryl, I'll do my utmost to fulfill the responsibilities entrusted to me."

Warren offered a measured smile, "Your cooperation is valued, Princess Entrapta. We believe this compromise ensures a smooth transition and maintains the stability of our great kingdom."

Orion, always the supportive figure, added, "You've proven yourself capable, Entrapta. Leading Chronos is a position of influence, and your role in the kingdom's defense will remain significant."

Isabella chimed in, "The reinstatement of Chronos aligns with our desire for progress and innovation. Your expertise will serve Dryl well in these challenging times."

Entrapta nodded in agreement, “I understand. I look forward to working with you all as equals. I will bring honor to Dryl and promise to work hard to make this the great nation it is.”

The board members each in turn nodded and began to gather their things, preparing to leave the imposing room. The echoes of the board's decision lingered. The road ahead was uncertain, but Entrapta felt a sense of determination to navigate the challenges that lay in wait.

Chapter 7: Age 23

Chapter Summary

> In this chapter, Princess Entrapta attends a diplomatic conference where she meets Alyn, an academically inclined young woman. As they engage in intellectual discussions and bond over shared interests, they find themselves locked in a heated debate about scientific possibilities and ethical dilemmas. Despite the disagreements, their interaction leads to a newfound friendship, much to the delight of Entrapta's mother.

Dark cordial music

https://youtu.be/rrfsfWrxfiA?si=6Set1djqa2lAL1Q3&t=32

The grand conference hall, a symbol of unity among the city-states, sprawled beneath a vast slightly arced dome of glass, allowing natural light to cascade onto the intricate geometric mosaic floor. The walls, constructed with a blend of sleek metal and transparent panels, reflected the modernity of the city-states of Dryl. Tables dotted around the grand hall where representatives of the city states of Sprokyte and Lyte mingled along with the main representatives of Dryl. Occasionally, diplomats in black and red garb would contrast and talk with the whites, purples and greys of Dryl's diplomats.

At the begging of Lysandra, Entrapta had gotten into formal attire again. She watched them all moving along drifting from topic to topic talking about things and places, who they knew, what they did. After the first fifteen minutes of hearing their words meander around not building towards anything meaningful she tuned them out and busied herself writing on a napkin. She chewed on the end of her pen trying to get the numbers to match up on the main assembly line one.

Entrapta heard, "The gear box."

Her eyes fluttered looking at the diagram she had in front of her. "What about the gear box?" she asked the voice.

A hand came and pointed at the spot on the napkin, "It's causing a harmonic disturbance because its chambers aren't broken up properly."

Entrapta's brows lofted at the seemingly-pseudo scientific theory. She looked over to who could possibly be talking.

She saw right away that this person was of academic background, her lapel board indicated that she was a graduate of Dryl academy just like her, only the colors indicated that she had her degrees in the biology departments with high honors. Three circles showed that she was in the middle of a doctorate program for an MD. Next to the pins she held a clipboard to her chest. Entrapta looked up, resting on her long neck was an oval face. She was a young woman like her, thin lips piercing green eyes and blonde hair pulled back by a hair clamp.

She watched Entrapta matter of factly and added, "The way that that's structured is going to start hitting a regular rhythm as it moves and is going to shake itself apart." The young woman set her out-of-place clipboard on the table and took out a blue pen scribbling on the napkin, "If you arrange the gears inside like this, you will lose some efficiency, sure, but at least it will work."

The engineer squinted at the napkin's new design, "Well if we *have* to set them up like that, we can just bring another gearbox in parallel and have them place the blanks in sequence with each other. I'm not too worried about losing a small amount of power if it means getting the thing to work right…"

A surprised smile hung on Entrapta's face, looking back up to the stranger, "Just who are you?"

She offered her hand, "Alyndrah Nulvis, Alyn to my friends. I am an intern under Doctor Lindayle.

Entrapta's pleased smile stayed at the corner of her mouth, she gave Alyn's hand a firm shake, "Well, Alyn… you just saved me… I don't know how many hours of wracking my brain on that problem. I'm Entrapta."

A small shock ran through Alyn's system, " *Princess* Entrapta?"

Entrapta looked to the side and lamented genuinely, "It's kinda weird, there's not really anyone else named Entrapta, is there? But yes, I am *that* Entrapta. Head of Chronos Manufacturing, last of the throne, all those things. I bet you wouldn't have even come up to me if you knew all that."

The woman gave a grimace, "I might've not, all I saw was someone thinking deeply in this sea of prattle and thought you would have the most interesting thing to say. But then again, if I knew you were *that* Entrapta, I might have still come over just to see if the rumors were true."

Entrapta laughed teasing, "And what would you have done if I said: 'Oh! greetings fellow academic, I see from your clothes that you must be from Lyte, what brings you so far from home?'"

Alyn rolled her eyes with a groan, "ughh, I might have tried to get out of the conversation quickly by saying something like, 'The renegotiation of the Horde of course! Say, do you know where the napkins are? I seem to need one and that you have one there.'"

The engineer chortled at the strange theoretical conversation, "Really? Napkins?"

Alyn flexed her brows, "Well you *had* a napkin and I knew that if you saw that I had missed the diagram, it would have *also* shown that I also had no mind between my ears to engage with."

Entrapta leaned back in her chair placing a hand on the table, a pleased tone to her voice, "Well it's a good thing that we didn't start out like *that* , I wouldn't have someone to bounce the rest of

my ideas off of in regards to the machine line." She gestured to the chair next to her.

Alyn's green eyes looked from the chair, then to Entrapta, she let a smile touch her lips.

Later…

The table now held around ten glasses in various states of full. Diagrams of the Chronos Machine line, a new surgery table, cellular structure and other half baked inventions were two layers deep on the table around them. Their voices echoed on the empty walls of the room, something heated between them.

"You can't just take the genome and dissect it like that!" Alyn jabbed her finger on the napkin, "It's just not *possible* to build a machine that would work better than the *existing* enzymes; they are completely capable of doing the modifications that you're talking about."

Entrapta firmly shook her head, "It's entirely possible, we just need to advance micro-mechanisims that are already being implemented in the toolbot project. Theres at least two teams of them almost running a line by themselves at Chronos. It's completely scalable!"

Alyn made an angry noise in her throat, her hands grasping at the air around Entrapta as she rose from her chair, "You're not listening, you can't just *say* something and believe it into existence!"

The princess rose in kind, pointing at Alyn's face, "I'm not! The whole purpose of the bot is to be scalable to any size, you're just mad because it hasn't been done medically before!"

Alyn's hands dropped tilting her head to the side, "And we haven't even started talking about the ethical medical dilemmas in regards

to that. This is such an impossible project! I need another drink!!”

The aspiring doctor almost crashed into Lysandra when she whipped around to head to the bar again. The queen smiled broadly at the situation, Alyn felt the table for her clipboard stammering, “Ahh! Y-Your majesty!”

Cheerfully she asked her daughter, “Who is your friend?”

Entrapta’s eyes widened, “Oh! Um… this is Alyndrah Nulvis of Lyte. We were… just working through something.”

Lysandra offered her hand to Alyn who was clinging to her clipboard suddenly, “It’s good to meet you! I’m very happy to see Entrapta reaching out to someone.”

In that moment Entrapta finally registered just how quiet things were around them. She asked, “Where… where is everyone?”

The queen chuckled, “You’ve been debating with this woman for almost three hours, the convention moved to the assembly hall and half of the diplomats have moved back to their quarters.”

Entrapta tilted her head, “You didn’t need me for anything there? I am supposed to be on the board of directors.”

Lysandra smiled kindly, “Nyland stepped up there, you were busy and he was happy to do so.”

Entrapta frowned slightly, “Oh… I guess that’s okay. He knows I *could* have helped.”

Her mother shook her head, “And interrupt this session between you two? Perish the thought. It’s so good to see you making a friend!” Lysandra grabbed Alyn by the shoulders, “You *must* come by the palace later and take a look at Entrapta’s lab! She has so many things that she’s stuck on.” She lowered her voice divulging, “She calls it her sanctum of shame.”

It made Alyn chuckle and give a sarcastic reply, "What? Entrapta entrenching in being stuck? *That* doesn't sound like her."

Entrapta frowned at the team up, "Oh you two gotta stop *that* right now."

"What??" the queen said in feigned shock, "I'm just talking about your room to your new friend, is that embarrassing?"

Entrapta started moving towards the exit of the room, "Kinda! Yeah!"

The three of them chuckled as they moved out of the great hall.

Chapter 8: Age 24

Chapter Summary

A lost memory, resurfaced

Age 24

The sun streamed through the tall, narrow windows framed by grey concrete on one side of the castle room. Their long, angular beams of light illuminated the almost cavernous space. The windows stretched from floor to ceiling, their glass slightly warped, creating rippling patterns on the pale, grey-white concrete walls. The sunlight was intense, almost golden, hinting at the oppressive summer heat outside. Yet inside, the air was crisp and cool, the faint hum of a recirculated air system a constant backdrop. There was a subtle tang to the synthetic air, a sterile contrast to the warmth pouring in through the windows.

At the center of the room was a sunken conversation pit, its cushions a rich purple trimmed with crisp white, arranged in casual disarray. Entrapta and Alyn were seated there, their animated debate spilling across a cluttered stack of haphazard papers. The two leaned forward, voices raised, their words bouncing off the hard surfaces of the room.

Stairs led up and out from either side of the pit, connecting to a hallway just beyond. The open design of the space encouraged flow, with personnel moving casually in the background, their steps echoing faintly in the otherwise quiet room. The room itself spanned roughly fifty feet in length and twenty in width, designed as a neutral space for open discussion between more formal meetings.

"It's your proposal, Alyn, but I think we really need someone who knows money-flow. Parker is going to be the man for it, he's retired but I'm sure that knowing Nyland wants him, and specifically him, patriotism will do the rest."

"But Nyland, doesn't want him specifically, *you* do, Entrapta! What happens when that comes to light?"

Entrapta looked up, falling back into the purple cushions, "I think that if he finds out, it will be months into his new job and he won't want to change being on the cutting edge of Dryl's cybernetics giant."

Alyn touched her forehead, "You're hoping that his ambition is greater than his sense of morality? Entrapta, the man's retired. He feels that he has done his part already. You would have me build this on a foundation of lies and sand. No, we're going with Barry."

Entrapta protested, "The I.S.B. guy? That guy won't know what to do in a lab!"

Alyn pointed at his application, "I want him, Entrapta. Barry's experience aligns with the operational logistics necessary for a research-driven institution. His background in managing interdisciplinary teams within the Integrated Systems Battalion shows he understands resource allocation, personnel dynamics, and the intricacies of research protocols. He's not coming in with a legacy of optimizing production matrices or prioritizing throughput over innovation!"

Entrapta looked at Alyn a long moment, a smile coming to the side of her face. The smirk was infectious, Alyn found herself smiling back, "What?" she finally said.

Entrapta repeated her mockingly, "Optimizing production matrices!"

Alyn complained through laughing, "What!? It's true!"

Entrapta closed her folder on Parker, "Well that's good enough for me then. Why don't we talk about something more fun? Maybe we could go back to the vision statement's wording?"

Alyn threw her pen across the pit with a dramatic groan, "Ugh, no! Who knew being a master surgeon wasn't enough? Now I'm stuck wading through paperwork!"

Entrapta tossed her pencil onto the table in solidarity. "It's because you're chasing the next horizon, and this is what it takes!" She grinned, "We're always moving toward the unknown, right?"

Alyn huffed, but her smile softened. She childishly demanded, "I want pizza."

Entrapta flopped on her side, "Me too, but not Danyel's pizza, they burn the crust."

Alyn talked towards the ceiling that was 20 feet above where they were sitting, "They -cook- their pizzas, they don't dip them in grease, breathe on it hard, call it cooked, and then hand it to you like they do at Stoneforge pizza."

Entrapta chortled at the exaggerated description, "Okay, then you go get charcoal pizza at Danyel's I'll get a sandwich, I'll have an aide do a run to Hy-light."

Alyn frowned, "You love the atmosphere at Danyel's… Besides, it's no fun going to a sit-down place by yourself."

Entrapta raised her brows, "Oh, so it's important I come with you then?"

Alyn smirked at Entrapta's attempt at psychology. She shifted back to sitting, "You know, it's not about the pizza, or the atmosphere, or even the grease-to-charcoal ratio."

Entrapta tilted her head, feigning disbelief. "Oh really? What could possibly be more important than the sacred art of pizza criticism?"

Alyn softened her tone, "I dunno, maybe it's something about having someone at the table who can stand me. Who actually sees me for the person I am instead of a person that can save

their loved one… who *wants* me, instead of *needs* me. When we talk, Entrapta, it's because we both want to be there. Sure, maybe we had to do a little fighting to sit across the table from each other but-" A sigh escaped her, she smiled out of the side of her face, "You're nothing like I expected when I found the princess of Dryl doodling on napkins. You're really *here* when we talk… it's genuine."

As she had been talking, Entrapta had become less and less animated. By the time she was done Entrapta had to clear her throat. She said bashfully, "Well then…"

Alyn's green eyes widened, she had a knowing smile. Alyn's voice was bright, "So we're eating at Danyel's?"

Entrapta flinched, her mind trying to figure out how much of what she said was genuine, and how much of it was for her to feel guilty about insisting on her own preference on where they ate. She finally said, "You don't play fair!"

Alyn shrugged, "Every option is on the table when it comes to food."

Entrapta groaned through a broad smile, "That was terrible."

Alyn burst into laughter tossing a pillow at her.

As they gathered their things, Entrapta's heart felt lighter. She paused part way, "What *really* made you come to the conference last year?"

Alyn flinched, "I was following doctor Lyndale around."

Entrapta made a perplexed face, "But it was a diplomatic event with the *Horde* . We all know how peaceful and understanding they are. It's not really a place for a doctor."

Alyn was wrapping up the last of her papers, clipping the impressive stack with the clipboard she always had, "I suppose…

It's the same reason that drew Lyndale. Perhaps sizing up the enemy just like they were doing with Dryl."

Entrapta made an uncertain smile, "Maybe I need to pay more attention to my surroundings. I didn't get that feeling from them at all."

Entrapta shoved her papers into a purple hiking backpack just behind a book reading 'the tapestry of war' She asked Alyn, "So are you going to be taking on any interns, *Doctor Nulvis* ?"

Alyn shivered, a wry smile on her lips, " *You'd* better not start calling me Doctor. That's for the employees and patients."

Entrapta flexed her brows, confused, "Hey! Sometimes I get owies and I'm going to need a good doctor around to help patch me up! Besides, What's wrong with helping people?"

Together, they ambled along the hallway towards the exit. Alyn laughed dryly, "Nothing, I guess, it's a lot of responsibility, though. People already look at me as though I have all the answers all the time."

Entrapta scoffed as they pushed out the glass doors, "Well all they have to do is look at your pizza choices to realize *that's* not true."

Alyn gave her a playful scowl, refusing to engage.

Alyn squinted at the princess disapprovingly. There they were, in the middle of Danyel's the table dominated by their supreme pizza, each had a plate, each had a slice, but Entrapta was deep in food surgery. Her fingers were slick with marinara, eyes tranced on the patient, the sausages were being placed perfectly in a line down the centerline, pepperoni was bisected, framing either side of it. Olives were in the middle of being alternated on either side. The bell pepper and onion's fate in the triage was yet to be determined

The air was heavy with the smells of the wood-fire oven that gave the food its signature, rustic taste. There were children shrieking to play on the arcade cabinet and pinball machine just next to the bathrooms. The bar was filled with patrons enjoying beer nearby. The two sat in a booth that was part of a cluster of six with high backing for privacy and decorative stained glass that let light in at a seam at the top. The seats were plush leather but dark, they shared a warm light that hung from the ceiling. The lined paper notebook was open, stained with Entrapta's marinara fingerprints.

Alyn, was looking down her glasses at Entrapta whose tongue was peeking out of the side of her mouth in silent concentration.

Alyn's voice was deadpan as she said, "Vitals are holding. Is the patient in need of epinephrine, or are we still prepping for transplant?"

Entrapta's attention drifted up from the pizza, "Oh…" she hummed, "I think we're actually about ready to close."

Alyn touched her forehead, embarrassed for the both of them.

Entrapta leaned back and sprinkled the peppers and onions on the slice, "You know, it's not my fault that they haven't optimized the flavor profile on their individual slices."

Alyn dabbed at her lips with her napkin, "You know, the variety in what you find with each bite is part of the fun in eating supreme pizza. If you wanted consistency, we really should have gone with pepperoni."

Entrapta shook her head, turning the piece to nibble on the tip, "No… there's still problems with that, unequal parts of pepperoni on each slice."

Alyn pointed her finger across the table, "Well, you'll be horrified to know that once in a great while people have something called Situs Inversus. Their whole body is flipped horizontally on the

inside, liver and heart on the opposite side. Most people live completely normal lives never knowing."

Entrapta pointed at her pizza, saying "But no extra sausages or half sausages."

Alyn laughed, "No sausages inside their bodies at all hopefully. The point is, you're spending a lot of time preparing and not enough time savoring."

The purple princess sat back, licking her fingertips, "I gotta admit, it's messy, maybe we could make a microbot swarm that could go through and do the work for me."

Alyn clearly gave up and took another bite, saying sarcastically, "Great, I'm sure we can upload a generalized pizza layout to them and they could just wash over the whole thing adapting to what's in the pizza's DNA and just fix it, all for you, princess."

Entrapta's eyes widened to saucers, looking up from the slice at Alyn.

She recognized the look, "What?"

Entrapta frantically slapped her hand on the notebook between them and madly scribbled, "Yes! Yes! Like hot little chefs! Except, there's no DNA in *pizza!* "

She turned around the paper showing off her diagram showing off a box with a doctor's mask on it, "but *people* do! We can use the toolbot design and build them itty bitty! They could integrate with the body's natural cells and receive their special coding to learn how to close up the wound that they're applied to!"

Alyn's face shifted from doubt, to shock, to suspicion, "And… a limited charge on them so they don't fully and permanently integrate with the body, right?"

Entrapta was busy scribbling circuitry, "Uhh yeah! Yeah. They'll find their way out like everything else." She waved her hand

dismissively.

Watching her work so quickly Alyn started to see mistakes piling up, she pointed, "I suppose you could bridge the storage of all that data over the whole of the swarm… and then…"

Their voices mingled in low bursts of excitement, passing the note pad back and forth, one idea turning over late into the night, past closing. By morning, they would have a proposal for Nanotech Bandages ready for the board.

Chapter 9: Age 26

Chapter Summary

> In this chapter, Entrapta grapples with her father's decision to negotiate with the Horde, only to later confront a shocking revelation about his safety and motives when a mysterious diplomat arrives with unsettling news and a signed contract, leaving her questioning the true intentions behind the agreement.

Dark Ambient music again

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Yk2bpo5paPw

The invention went sailing away with her furious throw. The box's reflective surfaces winked back to her as it tumbled edge over edge in the setting sun. The silence after made Entrapta's breath, panting in and out of her almost deafening. She brought her wrist to her forehead murmuring, "Stupid…" to herself.

When she opened her eyes again she looked out over the land that Dryl looked out over. The mountain's height gave a panoramic view of a good portion of Etheria. To her left, distantly, black smoke belched into the air poisoning Darkland, now called the Fright Zone. Before her were the Dryl prairielands, now peppered with greens, oranges and reds starting to let go of their summer colors. To her right was the whispering wood also turning its leaves dim, and she knew beyond that was pastel land of Brightmoon. The autumn wind swept up the side of the mountain tussling her purple hair haphazardly around her face. She felt her hands tighten and relax steadily trying to release more of the fury in her heart. The simple text that had come over Entrapt-net still gouged at her guts. 'It is decided and required that King Nyland is to be our representative in the new contract negotiations with the Horde.'

"The kingdom of snows is a neutral territory, Entrapta." came Nyland's voice, "It's safe."

Entrapta bit her cheek looking up at the sky. She said firmly, haltingly, "You. Are. King." She turned from the edge of the wall looking at her father, "Send the board members, send Evelyn, send Warren! They are the ones that are contract specialists!"

Nyland shook his head, "The Horde has threatened to completely pull out of weapons negotiations if we don't send someone with broad generalized powers like he does. He hates deliberation and needs immediate answers. Anyone on the board wouldn't be able to act on their own like I can."

She patted her chest, "Send *me* then. I am a princess and a board member! If things turn sour then the board could blame me and finally get me out of their hair!"

Nyland shook his head, "What about me then, your mother?"

She turns profile to him then, "What of it? You two wouldn't have your failure of a daughter that you have to take care of around anymore either."

Nyland closed the distance and pulled her by the shoulder and scolded her, "Don't you *ever* talk about yourself like that!"

Entrapta's mind rolled back to her instincts being held roughly by her father. She said through sudden tears the essential truth she held, "Don't go, Daddy…" her forehead thumped into his chest.

The king sighed and patted his daughter's back, "Entrapta… It's just a negotiation. Why are you so worried about this?"

Her forehead pitched back and forth on his chest, "Because he's a dictator, he manipulates everything he comes in contact with. Deceitful, liar, smart, egotistical, sociopath."

He chuckled, "You've been talking with Alyn too much."

Entrapta stepped back, looking him in the eye, "You don't know, Dad. She's smart, she's *so* smart. Remember that conference a few months back? She accurately predicted not only what their project was going to be about, but how many of the board members were going to pass or not pass it. All she did was look at the way he adjusted his tie and the tone of his voice. It's like she has a manual on everyone's behavior." She shook her head slightly at him verbally underlining, "She's told me that this isn't an 'in good faith' negotiation. He has something planned."

Nyland thinned his lips pensively, "I can't start thinking the worst of people just because your friend has some kind of insight. I have to go with my gut on this and it's telling me that we need to give Hordak a chance to get a clean contract that isn't tainted by the board or any prior dealings with our factories. I'm going to set up something with Chronos. I promise you, it will be done with good faith. We've even been exchanging preliminary drafts of the agreement, you can look them over if you like. Everything he says appears to be above board and seems to genuinely understand that Dryl's technology is conditional on our freedoms from his campaigns. If he ever takes aggressive action towards us, we are ready to make sure that any of our technology will never be usable by anyone."

When Entrapta scowled to the side Nyland pressed, "Okay, I'll humor you. Let's pretend that Hordak is stupid enough to do something in the kingdom of snows. It would mean that the army of the kingdom of snows would be engaged, Whatever small group that was there would have to travel miles through hostile territory, then traverse the Crimson Wastes to get back to the Fright Zone. Even pretending that he could somehow do that, it would mean that ancient treaties would be engaged and the kingdoms of Brightmoon, Plumeria, and Salineas would solidify into one nation under the Hierophant Alliance against the power that would threaten any one of the ancient king bloodlines. *Nobody* arranges a diplomatic event and then uses it for combat."

She glared at Nyland then, letting her red eyes watch the honest and good man her father was, such hope was there, such

confidence in what he had said. Her very bones were telling her that this man wouldn't lie to her, couldn't lie to her. She couldn't argue his points that it would be seemingly suicide to take aggressive military action during a contract negotiation. Things just don't work like that. Additionally, Chronos was *his* company originally. He wasn't about to risk all his stakes on something that he didn't absolutely believe in.

She heaved a breath and turned to walk a short way along the wall that looked out over the land. The sun was even lower now casting long black lines through the buildings below, her own face in shadow. She couldn't shake all the times that Alyn would surprise her by giving her an answer to something she was just about to ask, almost as though she was psychic. 'Simple deduction and reading body language' she would always say. She turned to look back at her dad who was still there waiting.

Finally she asked, "Why even talk to me about this? You're going to do it anyhow. The Horde weapons that Chronos is making are starting to become a large part of our economy base. If they were to pull out Dryl would start to free-fall. There isn't a choice at all… why even come here?"

"Because," The king started, drawing close to her again, "If I left, and didn't at least speak with you about it, what kind of a father would I be? It would mean so much to me if you could see me off with hope in your heart for things to become better."

Entrapta's gaze softened, torn between conflicting sentiments. "I'll try, Dad. I'll try to see the hope you're talking about." She hesitated for a moment before adding, "At least, be as careful as you can. I know Alyn has her quirks but she's so seldomly wrong about people."

Nyland nodded understandingly. "I appreciate your concern, Entrapta. Just have faith in the path we're taking. And if you ever feel the need to share your worries or insights, I'm here to listen."

Entrapta painted a small smile on her face, her eyes reflecting both uncertainty and determination. "I'll keep that in mind, Dad. Safe travels."

Nyland placed a gentle hand on her shoulder before heading off. As Entrapta watched her father's retreating figure, she couldn't shake the lingering tension in her chest.

Weeks later…

Entrapta let the dice fall from her hands again. The two clacked on the metal of her desk again coming to a stop at the back of the desk next to a paper coffee cup. She looked up from the desk to a huge bay window that looked down on a three story mess of metal catwalks, stairways and automated machinery with yellow and black warning tape peppered throughout. The beast hummed along, the occasional human shout rang out over the spinning turbines, and clanging pistons. Workers moved from station to station wearing personal protective equipment even though it was only 9 o'clock almost all of them had grease marks at least somewhere on their bodies. A steady thud joins the industrial refrain of mechanical instruments all working in harmony with one another.

"I think you're developing a nervous tick," said Alyn.

Without looking away from the factory, Entrapta said hollowly, "I missed something, didn't I?"

Alyn slid over on the guest chair to where Entrapta had her impressive view of Chronos, putting a friendly hand on the shoulder of Entrapta's flight suit that she wore, "Yes, I was talking about how Eclypse Labs is getting close to it's ten percent of the city's national product. But that's fine, you're distracted because you think your parents have been gone for too long at this negotiation."

Entrapta made a face at the doctor, "It's so weird when you do that, it's like you're inside my head."

Alyn took her hand back teasing, "It's like it's my job to know what's going on in other people's heads."

It made her smile slightly, "Yeah…" the smile faded, "I mean… How could my dad have forgotten to tell me that Mom would be going too?"

Alyn's green eyes tilted to the side and increased the count to, "Eighteen."

Entrapta made a frustrated noise with her throat, "I don't *care* ! I'm bringing it up again!"

She stood up, holding her clipboard over her chest protectively, "Alright, then I'm going to bring this up again-"

Entrapta stood up too, trying to escape what she knew was coming but… well Alyn was in the way of the door to escape.

Alyn stared directly at her, "You told Nyland your suspicions, he knew that Hordak corrupted everything he touched and still he did it anyhow. He took his wife with him trying to do two things. One: Discourage the Horde from going through with it's attack, and-"

Entrapta moved to try and press past Alyn but she stubbornly cut her off. She took a hand off her clipboard to point at her shouting, "Two! If Hordak was going to go through with a suicide plan to turn this negotiation into a combat situation Nyland wanted to make absolutely certain that the people of Dryl would galvanize into a unified front and that the Alliance would have no choice but to form."

Entrapta glared at her friend, "He is *not* dead."

Alyn took her pointing hand back to her clipboard, pointing out, "Maybe not, but he is very late."

Entrapta jutted her chin out disarming her tone, "I should go there… they could use my help, I am their daughter and I can speak on behalf of the board."

Alyn reminded her, "The Horde wanted to re-negotiate with a single negotiator."

Entrapta glared a moment and then settled back into her chair, Alyn followed.

Entrapta's voice was exhausted, "He's smarter than this, something's not right about this whole situation."

The steady chaos of the factory noises seeped in around them filling their silence. Entrapta forced the two dice on her bench to become two fives.

Alyn prompted, "So… nothing about how Eclypse is nearly on the board of directors?"

Entrapta shook her head, guilt running over her, "I'm sorry. It's… it's great, I'm really proud of you. I'm just so preoccupied with this."

Alyn smirked, "And I'm trying to move your attention somewhere else. Come on… let's go have lunch, it will do you good to move."

Days Later…

The throne room of Dryl was imposing. Its concrete walls stretched high overhead. The space was vast and open, lacking the opulence associated with traditional throne rooms. In the center of the room, a massive throne sat upon a raised platform. The throne itself was a monolithic structure, also constructed from concrete, with sharp angles and straight lines. The seat was devoid of excessive ornamentation, embodying a minimalist and utilitarian design. The backrest rose imposingly, creating a sense of authority and power.

The room's walls held long tube lighting that glowed warm, casting an ambient light all around that was inadequate for filling the room completely with light, instead a comfortable dim warmth softened the features of those in the room. The throne itself was lit brightly with stronger lamps pointing directly down and casting sharp lines across its imposing simple geometry. Just behind the throne hung a flowing purple banner with three gears stationary but clearly locked into place with each other each representing the three city-states of Dryl, Sprokyte, and Lyte.

The usual somber quiet of the room was nowhere to be seen, a clamor of people were crowded around an ominous object just before the kingly seat.

"Fascinating." escaped from Entrapta's mouth. She tried to move forward but the guard clad in simple ballistic armor pressed a hand to her chest holding her back. There in the center of the room was a floating object that roughly looked like an enormous apple seed with the tip pointing down. It was glistening black, the air underneath warbled with the heat of exhaust, A single glowing red line ran around the top.

"Please, Princess, it's not safe, it survived the automated turrets to get in here." said one of the guards.

It only made her imagination run wild, "But… there's not a scratch on it!"

"Please, get back." the guard begged again.

"It's doing something!" shouted one of the nobility.

A seam silently formed from top to bottom in the shape of a doorway. The black material melted down before it and re-formed into stairs. Doing so revealed a figure inside the structure.

"A transport!" Entrapta gasped, while a giddy smile widened on her face.

The person inside wore a black tabard held close to their body by a white belt. She stepped down the stairs, widening her arms to either side of her as she came closer to the crowd that formed. She had brown hair and pale skin. Her eyes gleamed red in the dim light of the room and she spoke with more than one voice in unison in an empty, full smile, "People of Dryl. I bring to you news from the conference of the kingdom of snows."

Entrapta, unable to contain her curiosity, pushed the guard away to confront the diplomat.

The woman locked her gaze on the princess, "Be at ease, for Hordak has taken your leaders into his protection from the aggression taken at the conference by the kingdom of Snows. They have broken sacred oaths of the past and attacked the King of Dryl. Though he does not recognize the Hierophant Alliance, he would like to work with it to help destroy these aggressors that did not honor their role as neutral grounds for Dryl to talk with the Horde."

Entrapta staggered, her world shattered with the cheerful sounding decree, "No…" she whispered, "No, they wouldn't do that, Dryl did nothing to them!"

The diplomat kept her smile, "When the Kingdom of Snows learned the nature of the contract with Dryl was an arms contract, they dissolved their agreement with hosting this negotiation. They ignored the sovereignty of our two nations to peacefully work out agreements with each other, then they egregiously attempted to take both of our leaders into their custody."

Entrapta covered her mouth. Her eyes darted around trying to work out just what was being said. Rage built in her heart at the betrayal of the claim but it just didn't add up that they would do such a thing. She accused with a scowl, "You're lying! They… they wouldn't!"

"Behold!" The diplomat produced a paper and held it in front of her.

Entrapta glanced back at the crowd and the guard. She visually harrumphed realizing that the diplomat was going to make her come to them. Entrapta took the ten or so paces to get to her and took the paper to inspect. Her red eyes drifted back and forth a moment, then skipped to the bottom. Her fingers went numb seeing…

She looked up from the paper back to the gathering, more of them were coming closer. Entrapta told them, "It's a finalized contract with Chronos Manufacturing. It's… it's signed by Nyland… stamped with his blood seal."

She looked suspiciously at the strange diplomat, "How… how did you get this?"

The diplomat serenely smiled, "The only way *to* get it. With the full authority of Dryl's king." She looked over the gathering of people, "People of Dryl. These weapons are not to be used against you. They are to be used against the incoming extraterrestrial threat of Horde Prime. He comes for us all, should we not be prepared with our greatest minds and best armaments, we will all perish in his light. What you do in your factories shall be our salvation from his oppressive yoke. Blessings of Hordak upon you for your role in this campaign against oppression. We look forward to working with your people, for the good of all Etheria."

Many people had crowded around Entrapta now looking over the paper. She looked back to the diplomat whose pale face still had that same serine and unchanging smile. She said, "Technology, for a purpose." before returning to the strange pod.

Entrapta didn't look at the leaving diplomat, didn't see the stairs melt back up into a protective layer for the pod. She just looked at the paper and the terminology of the agreement. "Stars…" she murmured, "What have you done, Dad?"

Chapter 10: Age 27

Chapter Summary

> Tensions rise as Princess Entrapta finds herself embroiled in diplomatic disputes with representatives from the Kingdom of Snows. Despite attempts to maintain order, arguments erupt, leading to accusations and threats. Entrapta struggles with her past and present responsibilities, eventually opting to step back from negotiations. However, events take a drastic turn as news of an invasion reaches them, throwing the situation into chaos.

Still Dark ambient music

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OW-FlfUu4vI

"Dryl is only providing weapons to the Horde because they are paying for our services. You are welcome to engage in those same channels of commerce." Warren said.

The diplomat again looked at Entrapta's direction. It was different being on this side of the council table. Her red eyes drifted from person to person that she shared the board of directors powers with. Once they opposed her, now she knew them as the people they were. Even Evelyn had evoked a chuckle or two from her over the past few months. From Evelyn's current discerning glower, however, Entrapta knew that she was being judged by the ceremonial red cape on her shoulders that clashed terribly with her purple jumpsuit. She didn't care. She had somehow convinced herself that this was going to be a brief meeting with the Kingdom of Snows. Those hopes had long died out, somewhere at the end of the first hour.

She had to speak up, "I'm sorry, Warren, if this derails things, but I grow tired of every other sentence coming from you to be ignored due to our… guest here looking over at me."

The man in blue replied, "It's just… I don't understand why you're not in charge here, Entrapta. You *are* the princess of this land, are you not?"

She grit her teeth remembering how the council ended the monarchy powers.. Her voice said grimly, "I am director of the Chronos Manufacturing site. I happen to be the daughter of the last king that stood for us before your people attacked us!"

"That's a lie! We never did such a thing!" he retorted.

Warren stiffened and clacked a gavel, "Order!" he called out to curb any of the bickering that was sure to follow.

Entrapta dropped the subject, she chopped her hand in the representative of the Kingdom of Snow's direction, "He should have a contract with us first before we even listen to him. Let him pay us for our time at least!"

He said discouraged, "Fine, give us a contract, any contract!"

Isabella leaned forward into the reflected light off the diplomat and smirked amusedly over at Entrapta, "So, Entrapta, you work with the Arms and Armor council. Do they have any open slots for new contracts?"

Entrapta rolled her eyes, after all these years she still disliked her connection to the Dryl Military arm. "While I sit here, I don't speak for the Arms and Armor council. He would have to reschedule and ask them directly."

The diplomat from the Kingdom of Snows raised his fists, "This is so infuriating! All of this three-card-monte politics seals our suspicions of you harboring spies! I will take these conclusions back to our nation and you will regret treating me this way! Death to traitors to the Hierophant Alliance!"

Entrapta slapped the table rising to shout back but Evelyn beat her to it, "You dare invoke that alliance when you, yourselves are the ones who tried to assault our *king!?!* "

He pointed at Evelyn shouting back, "We're not the ones that have sided with an alien to this world! Technology for a purpose indeed! I'm sure that nestles in your robotic minds all too well!"

Warren shouted over both of them, "This is a sacred place of order! Petty bickering is not permitted! Guards! Escort this man out!"

Men moved from the darker parts of the room to the stone slab that he stood on. He stepped off and shouted, "I can see *myself* out! I know when my words are being wasted in front of a gaggle of rubes!"

Entrapta tugged down her flight suit to neaten it and started to gather papers before her, thinking the meeting over. When she glanced up she noted the other members weren't moving. A wince came to her face, "We're not done?"

Evelyn laughed, "I really like how you asked him to pay us for our time and then said that he had to reschedule before he could even do that."

Warren frowned at the head of LumenTech, "Evelyn…" he warned. He regarded Entrapta then, "It's not wise to incense someone that represents a nation with the military might that the Kingdom of Snows has."

Entrapta folded her arms, "They attacked *us* first! Now they want to talk."

Warren pursed his lips and replied, "There is significant evidence that the Horde raised arms first. The kingdom of snows do not have the surveillance that we have and the Horde has not released their recordings of the event."

Entrapta showed off a paper, "Yes, and we have *contracts* with the Horde that have gone through discovery whereas we do not have any such thing with the Kingdom of Snows, a people that trust in *magic* to protect them."

Warren replied, “Magic is a fine way that a people can live.”

“A fine way to live…” Entrapta echoed, literally biting her tongue which made her jaw stick out, “What’s their casualty count up to today? Mmm? What’s life like for their people now that they’ve invoked the wrath of the Horde?”

The council looked uncomfortably at each other.

Isabella was first to speak up, “Plumeria and Sileneas believe that the Horde struck first.”

Entrpata shook her head, “Great, the flower people and the people with a navy believe in the people who use snow magic to fight when the Horde is likely to attack by land.” She makes a frustrated noise, “This is a stupid conversation. The kingdom of snows is already fighting an overwhelming enemy, it does them no good to fight us, instead they should be making a deal with our military, not badgering us about outing non-existent spies!”

Warren’s voice tensed, “I believe that you are letting this personal wound that you’ve sustained cloud your judgment, Entrapta. Perhaps you should remove yourself from the board because of that involvement.”

Entrapta tightened her grip on the contract with the Horde. She wished Alyn was here so she could explain this better to them. What did she say about anger again? Count to three? one … two…

Entrapta took a heavy breath, “Actually… Warren, you’re right. I’ve behaved poorly here and ask that the board forgive my outburst.” She paused for a moment, then said softly, “In fact… I would like to take your council and ask that I might be allowed to sit out further negotiations with the kingdom of snows. I request that the diplomat be recalled with my personal apologies. I trust that you all will be able to explain how I was compromised earlier.”

Warren relaxed in his chair, he said, "Your actions are noted. Your father would have been proud of your decision here."

The sentence made her freeze, Warren was talking in the past tense. She locked her red gaze at him sternly, correcting, "You mean, he will be proud."

Warren stayed quiet for a beat, then relented, "Yes… when he returns."

Days later…

In the dim light of the Arms and Armor, I.S.B. division command center, Joesyf tapped his monitor making the phosphor screen flicker. Then he did it again. It definitely wasn't a glitch. He was a flight master of drone 7, monitoring the border between the Kingdom of Snows and Dryl. It was a routine job, very easy. When the Snow army skirted the border all he had to do was send a message through the network to his C.O. to let them know and he would get a readout for how long they were going to be moving through Dryl territory. He had been doing it for about a month now. This was different though. The drone had registered a movement, he sent his message to the C.O. and then, all the camera equipment locked. He tapped a few keys bringing up a readout of what instruments were working. All he had was the altitude readout which was spiraling down and the thermometer which read -51°C.

Joesyf stood up in the dim room of the Arms and Armor monitoring system, "Sir… Can I get another pair of eyes on this? I think Drone 7 is in freefall from its engines… icing up."

Shortly…

Entrapta held her flowing hair from her eyes and quickly wrapped it up into a ponytail. A crowd of people around her were hurling

information all around. Unit movement, drone deployment, weather conditions in particular keept being shouted.

"The cloud wedge is clearly moving against the wind following after the eight divisions heading straight towards-"

"They could be moving to establish camp-"

"-Drones two and six are now offline-"

"-calculations say six feet of snow-"

"Sir, we need to quickly remove the machine lines that were dedicated to the Hierophant Alliance-"

"Casualties include eight transport trucks and seven civilian-"

"-authority to deploy reinforcements?"

She tried to delegate through the chaos grabbing papers, shouting and signing on clipboards moving forward through it all until she rounded the last corner to the war room where she saw two very familiar figures, Isabella and Alyn.

Alyn's usual crisp ponytail was a mess, her fingers were white holding her clipboard. She rushed up to Entrapta stopping a foot from her having to shout over the cacophony of voices, "What's happening!? My father left me a message about troop movement and then was cut off!"

Isabella grabbed Entrapta's shoulder and pulled her towards the war room. The princess moved with the director of the drone program, speaking hurriedly with her friend with the hope she could pacify her quickly, "Alyn this is a developing situation, I can't talk about the details right now."

Anger flashed across Alyn's face and she grabbed Entrapta's other arm, " *No* , you don't get to hide behind your position of power here. Lyte is under *attack* isn't it?"

The fight over her stalled when Entrapta tugged against Isabella. The crowd quieted, Entrapta was in the doorway to the dark war room. Alyn was clutching her arm with one hand, the other tightly on the clipboard at her side.

Isabella let go and sharply said, "Princess, you're needed in operations *now.* "

Alyn's tense expression punctuated her beg, "Don't leave me out here, *please* Entrapta."

Entrapta stared at the doctor a moment, huffed and then twisted her hand to hold her's, "Alright, just get in here, you are a *fly on the wall* do *not* interrupt, you are an *observer.* "

https://youtu.be/Gx0fs8oPJAk?si=GOOuMd7521043DjI&t=1154

Alyn's lips were tired from being clenched. A while back someone was nice to bring her a chair to sit on.

She didn't sit though.

Her world was crashing down. She couldn't do a thing about it.

But she could stand though.

She was still in the situation room. Men were moving in and out like disturbed ants. They were coming in with new reports, new information that was too secretive to broadcast over the network. Earlier they had discovered that the network was compromised by some sort of rogue program. Time had no meaning now. Readouts were being hand-typed across the territory of her home. A 'confirmed dead' readout held steady at 655.

Earlier… or was it now? No… it was earlier. The readout was 30 when the Lyte constable shrieked to death on the radio.

She understood completely what was unfolding. Trauma was being pressed into her mind. She wanted it to fragment her sooner so that she could start understanding what was going to be a flashback and what wasn't.

A man came rushing in to report to the table.

"Line is confirmed secure and legitimate. We have the Horde liaison on the line."

Entrapta nodded and he ran off. She could see the tension building in the princess's posture. Despite her lack of monarchy powers, Alyn could tell that everyone around her was falling into line. They all knew that she was still the most qualified person in the room to handle this kind of crisis.

Alyn felt her mind lock on the messenger, trying to discern his legitimacy as an agent of Dryl. The Kingdom of Snows was invading because of spies. They wouldn't do that unless they were certain and she was an expert at reading people. She could help people here. She noted that he carried himself with urgency, his pupils were contracted confirming his panicked state. His pace was fast but controlled. He passed.

Her eyes started surveying the others in the room, mentally interviewing each one. That would help pass the time and she could interrupt them if she knew for a fact that there was a traitor among them.

Moments later the channel opened and a forever smiling woman with brown hair came through. Alyn felt her eyes widen immediately, seeing nothing cognizant about the woman, only a shell of what might have been a person at one point.

Nobody else in the room seemed phased by the horror. Entrapta opened with, "Thank goodness, are you seeing what the kingdom of snows is doing?"

"Our visuals on the kingdom of Dryl are limited, please explain." the shell replied sweetly.

She could tell Entrapta understood the dig; many reports were filed against her and her observation missions. She did know to maintain her candor, "The kingdom of Snows has passed the border between Dryl. They have launched an invasion of Lyte."

Because of the mention of her city being invaded, Alyn knew that her body was flooding her with chemicals designed to create a fight or flight reflex, but she wasn't allowed either at the moment. She also knew that they were at such a level that she was going to be dissociating now and for-...

Something in the next few moments shattered through the haze.

Entrapta said, "Yes… yes we want the Horde's help."

Back to dissociating.

Another phrase she understood, Entrapta's voice was heightened, "I want to talk with Hordak! This isn't helping!"

Alyn's wide eyes turned to the counter. 830.

Dissociating.

Next, she was on her knees, voice breaking in a feral belly scream. Then another. Entrapta rushed over to her, so were strangers. Where was her clipboard?

"You can't throw things in here! Have you lost your mind?" Entrapta was holding her. Her friend looked like she was crying.

The voice Alyn tried to speak with couldn't have been her's. It was asking for her clipboard. Why would she do that right now when there were… No.

The number was 1,124. That was…

The Lyte map was red. The Horde was using their own arc program to invade and fight the invaders of the Kingdom of Snows. Only theirs wasn't about moving bullets in arcs, it was

about tracing where the target was going to move and fire high powered lasers that didn't care about cover. Somehow she remembered that.

Entrapta and the group had pulled her up. Someone was crying in the darkness. Alyn finally said something that came close to how she was feeling. She was shrieking, "There's only 2200 people in Lyte!" She was being pulled back into the bright hallway.

"There's going to be ***nobody left!*** "

Now that she was in the hallway. She couldn't look for spies.

It was later than before.

Alyn's lips were tired from being clenched. A while back someone was nice to bring her a chair to sit on.

She didn't sit though.

Her world was crashing down. She couldn't do a thing about it.

But she could stand though.

… Lyte is destroyed

Someone was weeping on her.

They had said that. "Lyte is destroyed."

She smelled of engine. Her hair was purple. “Entrapta?” Her alien voice asked.

Entrapta held her tight, weeping openly. She was apologizing.

“Clipboard?” Alyn softly asked.

She couldn’t understand why Alyn was asking for it. Alyn’s voice begged, “Please?”

She left and came back. The protection was held out for her to take. Alyn felt her neck swing her head back and forth ‘no’ like a marionette. Entrapta didn’t understand what she meant. The doctor turned the clipboard around in Entrapta’s hands and crossed her wrists around it like Alyn usually did. It made Entrapta weep harder than before.

Alyn held her friend tight, now that she was letting herself feel fully in the moment. She was a doctor, helping her friend. Alyn’s tears finally came to her for the first time, following trails from the dissociated person she was earlier.

Chapter 11: Age 28

Chapter Summary

> As they discuss the progress of their groundbreaking project Chimera, Alyn's suspicions about Entrapta's loyalty to Dryl begin to surface. Despite their close friendship, Alyn confronts Entrapta about her perceived bias towards the Horde and her suspicious actions. Entrapta, grappling with her own fears and uncertainties, reveals a failsafe device to Alyn, expressing her trust in her friend to safeguard Dryl's interests.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nCwl0z0ZeQw

Alyn's dedicated office was an organized hub for data analysis. Long oblong windows looked out at a copse of lush trees letting in natural lighting. That was complimented with recessed strip lighting letting a soft glow permeate throughout the room. The room's ambient lighting could be adjusted to suit various moods, from focused work sessions to moments of relaxation. She sat in front of a flat screen tube monitor hooked up to a powerful computer. An advanced microscope for detailed genetic examinations was also on the neatly arranged desk. Nearby from floor to 13 ft ceiling were shelves adorned with vials of colorful liquids displaying various genetic materials, while preserved specimens with animal-like features were labeled and arranged for study. Alyn's personal touch was evident through small potted plants, framed photos, and a comfortable ambiance amid the scientific precision.

In one corner of the room, there was a small lounge area with comfortable seating, inviting colleagues or collaborators to engage in discussions. The subtle hum of advanced air purifiers maintained a crisp and clean atmosphere, contributing to an optimal working environment.

Alyn stared at the rotating schematic on the monitor, it was the completed project that she and Entrapta had been working on for

four months. She finished the final calculations this morning. It was all so simple, take the existing variants in the population of the animal enhanced species and increase the variant factors. Make sure that the zipper nanites adhered to the harmonic frequencies that the creature was resonating on their Soul Harmony Frequency. It was brilliant. They had made it together. Her green eyes squinted at the breakthrough. It was in testing, the board had approved funding. This meant so much, they could literally edit DNA now. It meant at least twelve genetic diseases could be cured in just the first iteration of the program. It could make lizardfolk breathe puffs of fire like their ancestors with tougher scales. Magicats could hone their claws to diamond edge and hear the softest sounds. Beastfolk could lift incredible weight and survive indefinitely In snowy climates. Scorponi still needed some work since insects had diverged from humanoids much earlier in evolution but the second iteration of project Chimera should handle that without issue.

Her eyes lifted to Kayle through her office windows down at the cubicles in the next room. She knew that he was a sympathizer at least. She had been studying his behaviors around the coffee machine. But was he a *spy* ? She had successfully outed Dayna as a spy. It earned her praise from the Arms and Armory council. As a result, Eclypse Labs was given something called a 'fast track' to indoctrination to the board of directors. Rewards meant that she would perform that task again, more effectively. There were always more… spies.

Entrapta pushed open the door to her office and tossed a grey file at Alyn's pristine desk. She smiled broadly, "Well, you've really done it this time."

Alyn silently tilted her studying eyes to the folder, then to Entrapta, "The gears are already in motion, Eclypse is to be indoctrinated onto the board of directors no later than mid-August.

Alyn's hand reached out to touch the official document. A simple, "... remarkable" sounded out of her throat.

She watched her friend for the past five years. Perhaps it was because of how she was looking at Kayle just now but she's never thought of Entrapta as a spy. The tools came to her then easily, the doctor looked her over bringing her suspicions to bare.

Entrapta's brows raised and she huffed, "Don't get excited or anything, it's only the chance to make a real impact on Dryl, becoming financially free from having to fully answer to the board."

Alyn was listening to Entrapta somewhere, but she was deep in analysis pulling from her trauma the way that she asked for Hordak directly. The agreement to let the Horde inside their borders… the result.

She remembered Entrapta's prejudice against magic and how it made her short sighted when dealing with the Kingdom of Snows, favoring the Horde's structure when dealing with contracts.

Since the last time that the Kingdom of Snows sent a representative, the kingdoms of Brightmoon and even Mystacor had signed into the Hierophant Alliance against the Horde… Not Dryl. All that Dryl had done there was extend invitations to supply the Alliance with any weapons that they might need in their defense against the Horde. They had cordially declined stating that they did not want to work with someone with conflicted interests to their ideals.

The sudden attention that she was receiving further catapulted her suspicions. Both her and Entrapta worked on very cutting edge technology giving them access to the most advanced resources that Dryl had to offer. Those same resources were being distributed more and more sparingly now that Horde troops moved freely inside their territory disrupting supply lines from Sprokyte, the other major city.

"Alyn?" Entrapta repeated, "You're staring."

Alyn pressed the folder aside.

Her green eyes kept staring for a beat, she wetted her lips unsure how else to put this, "Entrapta… we've known each other for… five years now. We have both gone through great trauma in one way or another."

Alyn pointed at Entrapta, ferocity was in her expression, "Before you object to that, I won't let you make this about your parents. That is a *deflection* from the subject."

Entrapta settled her shoulders, Alyn was correct, she was about to launch into defenses.

From her chair she lectured, "Your actions regarding the Horde create a disturbing pattern. You have an obvious prejudice against all the other nations that are aligning themselves against the Horde just because they choose a different backbone to their societies. This is evidenced in your continuation of the ballistic and armament supplies that are being shipped out of Chronos to the Horde monthly. They are disrupting our economy as they are blockading essential food and mundane building materials from crossing the countryside. The timing of this promotion of Eclypse Labs to the board of directors is suspicious at best. Despite dwindling resources, project Chimera marches on with its schedule uninterrupted."

While the outpouring happened to her Entrapta gently shook her head back and forth taking it all in. A quaking breath escaped Entrapta after. She then walked silently over to the alcove of chairs that Alyn had set aside for casual conversation and drug one over the short distance to Alyn's desk. She sat into it and reached for Alyn's hand on the desk.

"I… am so sorry. I see that we're in completely different spots right now and I don't know how that happened." she began, "I… am *scared* right now Alyndrah. So scared." She shook her head confessing, "I am so scared that my parents are dead but I have no bodies or footage to confirm or deny that. I have a contract with the horde that is signed by my father with a blood seal that I

have to follow because it was made by *him* . Do you remember the confirmation tests we ran on it?"

Alyn nodded. She ran them herself.

"If there's… a *chance* they're alive. I have to act as though it was a certainty. I have to trust the Horde to not break their word and that they're protecting them. They are clearly better than we are at protecting our own right now. I'm a terrible general. I don't know how to get the horde out of our borders and it haunts me that I was responsible for that." Entrapta looked to the side, "Look… I see how it looks like my loyalties might be compromised. I… I want to do something. Something that I wouldn't trust with anyone else."

Alyn just kept watching her wondering what her friend might say, perhaps for the first time.

Entrapta reached into one of the pockets of her flight suit and produced a hexagonal chip. She said, "Do you see this?"

A dubious expression rose on Alyn's face at the simplistic question. Entrapta explained, "This… is a failsafe." Entrapta turned Alyn's hand over and pressed it into her palm, "This. Stops. Everything. Whatever my primary project is, it burns it out of the system. You know I always structure my computer files in a very particular way, specifically so that I can stop them with a single action if I ever need to."

Alyn picked up the little green hexagon up with her finger and thumb to look at. She asked, "So if I put this into my computer here, it would burn out project Chimera?"

Entrapta clearly was unsettled by the thought darting her eyes to the drive, then back to Alyn. She nodded, then said, "I clearly didn't plan on giving this to you today. Didn't plan on giving it out ever… I want you to take it and listen to me when I say: I stand with Dryl. Our people matter most to me. Our inventions and our work that we do is most precious to me. I *trust* you with

everything Alyn. If I'm doing something that will harm those ideals I *want* you to use it."

She looked the precious little thing over, turning it over to its shiny side, then back to the eprom side. Her gaze focused from it to Entrapta who again glanced at the vulnerable disc drive. Alyn took a heavy breath and accepted the item tucking it into her lab coat pocket at her chest.

She smiled, perhaps for the first time in months, "Well then… let's make sure that we keep that away from there, shall we?"

Chapter 12: Age 29

Chapter Summary

In this chapter, Alyn marvels at Entrapta's latest invention, a revolutionary tool system integrated into her hair. Their dynamic friendship shines as Alyn grapples with the implications of their groundbreaking project Chimera while dealing with personal challenges. Entrapta's caring nature prompts her to encourage Alyn's self-care, deepening their bond.

Night in cybercity -

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vqj_nbl4jSk

Alyn's green eyes were as big as saucers, "What… is that?"

Entrapta rolled out from under the machine. Entrapta mocked her question with her theatrical answer: "The *schematics* !"

In front of Alyn was a crumpled up blueprint, wrapped around it was a length of Entrapta's purple hair still attached to her head almost 10 feet away. Entrapta walked across the polished floor and began adjusting the dials of the hyperbaric chamber. Despite her motions the paper was completely stationary stretching the hair to suit the needed length.

Alyn, still trying to understand what was happening in front of her, protested, "I *see* the schematics, what are you doing with your hair??"

Entrapta looked back at her, unfazed and said, "Oh… that? I got sick of having to walk back to my toolbox each time I needed a tool."

Alyn looked at her exasperated, "Why not just wear a tool belt?"

“Don’t like ‘em.” Entrapta replied, turning back to what she was doing. A dial was wagging on the wall of readouts, she thumped it twice with her fist.

Alyn shook her head refusing to let the marvel become tertiary, “Entrapta, this is *amazing!* ”

Entrapta smiled, stepping back from the machinery that Chimera needed to function, completely missing what Alyn meant. She put her hands on her hips, “Yeah! This is going to change the way we think about life itself! We’re going to have people coming from thousands of miles away to get enhancements to their genetic-”

Alyn grabbed at the hair holding the plans and shook it at Entrapta shouting at her, “This!! *This* is amazing!!”

Entrapta willed the hairpiece to return to her, her eyes widened, “ *This* is a ridiculous solution to my stubborn-ass not wanting to wear a toolbelt. Can you imagine other engineers actually growing their hair out just so that they have another arm to work with?”

Alyn grabbed her by the shoulders, “Do you know how many nurses I’ve had to send out of surgery because they couldn’t hold the tools I needed right?? I want you to build me one of these right this second!!”

Entrapta winced, “ *Sounds* like you need to be better at communicating what you need to the nurses.”

Alyn waved an arm to the side her voice raising with each question, “How are you getting it to move? What muscles are you flexing? What kind of lifting power does it have!?”

The engineer patted the air in front of Alyn, trying to calm her down, “Look, I was just listening to you talk about how the muscles work with the brain to create a kind of circuitry and ran with it. I built a system that listens in at the Soul Harmony Frequency we all have and used that to extend the neural network out. With a little practice I can get it to hold stuff.” Entrapta

willed the ponytail to lay in her hand, "You know… I *could* sneak in a network of thin metal that would not only strengthen the hair but provide an adaptive set of tools for the user to control. Really all I was thinking about with this was holding stuff."

Alyn wagged a finger at Entrapta, "Once Chimera is complete, I want to see every note you have on this."

Entrapta snorted, "You mean the napkin?"

The two laughed.

Weeks later…

Alyn sluffed into one of the guest chairs in her office. Her hair was a mess, she took off her browline glasses handing them off to her ponytail to set aside. She rubbed at the bridge of her nose. "Lights down" she called to her Emily assistant. The lights of the office dimmed to about twenty percent. It had been a challenge of a day for her. Chimera had indeed been popular, so much so that the reputation had exceeded the volume of exams that they could do to approve candidates for the treatment. Alyn's schedule was booked clear through the end of the year and it was only June. She rubbed at her throbbing temples, a spot on her vision let her know that yet another ocular migraine was inbound.

Entrapta hopped up from Alyn's desk with a wide smile on her face. "I've got good news! The project launch of the Halo hair bands is nearly here. You were right, using another module offsets the strain that the mind has on controlling a singular Halo whereas two-" Entrapta cut her sentence short seeing how miserable Alyn looked, "Oh… right all the appointments." She looked at the clock, "And you're early again oh no… not another headache."

Alyn shook her head, "They're not as frequent anymore, I really think that I'm adapting."

Entrapta made a concerned face and took out a readout tablet. She plugged it into Alyn's ponytail. Her frown deepened, "You take this out at night, right?"

"I've… been up for twelve hours." The doctor admitted

Entrapta shook her head, "No, your readout says that it's been in for *nineteen* hours. Alyn, you're going to fuse your neurons to this one Halo!" You gotta slow down and get some sleep!"

"But the people need Chimera." Alyn started to protest getting up.

Entrapta pushed the doctor's tired body into the chair, "The people *need* Alyndrah. They need a doctor who knows what they're doing to help them. Otherwise they're just gonna dunk themselves in the tanks and come out with eighteen thumbs down their backs and tongues coming out of their eyes."

Alyn looked up at the princess frowning. "Alright… two hours of sleep, then I'm back to it."

Entrapta smirked, she had every intention of breaking her promise, "Sure, two hours."

Later…

Alyndrah bolted upright in the plush chair with a sharp gasp. Some imagery from someone being shot by a horde laser in Lyte still fresh, his shriek still echoing from her dreaming ears. She shuddered, wiping away at her eyes with her palm. She could feel her heart thrashing in her chest, knowing that panic would take her in a moment but it slowed when she realized that she heard snoring. Across from her was Entrapta sound asleep in the opposite chair. *Not alone… gotta keep my composure.* She was sitting in the office's alcove that was designed for talking with colleagues. Her eyes glanced over to the oval windows, they were dark. It had been much longer than two hours. She tried to use her hair to grab her glasses but it did no such thing. She

looked around for a moment for the Halo, finding it in Entrapta's hands. It really had become a part of her, she found it cumbersome getting to her feet without its assistance. She came over to study her friend. Something about her helplessness in sleep strummed at her heart. Entrapta worked so hard to make sure that innovation was at the front of everyone's mind around her. Awake, she was always moving, thinking, planning. But not right now. Now she was peaceful.

Alyn really did need her hair band though. She reached to take it from the dreamer's clutch. She had her hand on the band but it did rouse Entrapta from her rest.

A low, "Hey." came from Alyn.

Groggily Entrapta sat more upright in the other chair, "Oh man… I think I drifted off."

Alyn nodded, replacing the hairband on her head. It made Entrapta frown, "Really? Right away?"

The doctor nodded, "I have to get over to scheduling to see-"

Entrapta reached up from the chair taking her elbow in mid-attachment of the hair band, "No, hey… You *gotta* take a break here. Read a book, do something, anything else for a day."

She pitched her head slightly to the side, "Is that what you want, Entrapta?"

Her studying eyes watched Entrapta struggle with the question. She finally said, "I… want to work on the headband. See if I can figure out how to make it safer for you. Ocular headaches… They can lead to chronic migraines, could indicate that there's something really wrong happening in your head."

Alyn blinked her green eyes a moment, she flashed a smile. Of course it was about her well being, not-… something else.

She handed the hairband to Entrapta who gave a smile with half her face. Entrapta laid the band on her lap, "Thank you." she said.

"So what are we doing today?" Alyn presumed, "If I'm not working you're going to have to fill some of the space."

Entrapta's dark eyebrows lifted, she hadn't thought of that aspect of making Alyn take the day off. "Umm… picnic? Tech shopping?"

Alyn gave a shrug of her shoulder, "Pick something out, I don't care what, and we'll do it together later. I have some books to read that I've been putting off for too long."

Chapter 13: Age 30

Chapter Summary

Age 30: Chapter Summary

In the austere waiting room of Dryl's administrative building, Flora Bloomfield, with her vibrant and eclectic style, stands out amidst the sterile environment. Alyn, observing from a security office, notes Flora's every move, establishing a behavioral baseline. When Alyn, disguised as "Nora Torque," finally approaches Flora, they engage in a seemingly casual conversation that quickly reveals Flora's true identity.

As the interview progresses, Alyn discerns the secret behind the interviewee's nature. This revelation leads Entrapta to covertly agree to an unusual solution to a problem. This chapter captures the intricate dance of espionage, trust, and the shifting alliances necessary for survival in a war-torn world

Dark wave - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jb3fZO7kPPM

The waiting room in Dryl's administrative building was a stark space, illuminated by harsh overhead lighting. The walls, painted in muted tones, bore the weight of time with scuff marks and faded posters detailing city regulations. Uncomfortable plastic chairs lined up against the walls, and a worn coffee table displayed outdated magazines. The air, tinged with the faint scent of antiseptic cleaner, added to the overall sense of impersonality. A lone potted plant in the corner struggled for vitality, its leaves wilting in the sterile environment. The room, devoid of any personal touch, echoed the bureaucratic nature of the city. There, transplanted into the alien environment, was a bright blossoming girl. Her pale hair was saturated in rainbow highlights. It was hanging wild around her shoulders. She had a white peasant top and a dark teal overcoat with embroidered flowers. A wide

leather belt covered her midriff and baggy wine colored crushed vellum pants sagged around her legs. Peaking out of the bottom of those pants, her brown sandaled feet poked out from time to time.
She sat there, in the waiting room outside of the interview room. Alyn wasn't there though. She was in the security office. The woman on watch was kind enough to let her monitor one of her five screens. Alyn's green eyes stared intensely at the girl. She rested her chin on the palm of one hand. Next to her was a pad and paper with time stamps marked down. She had been watching for around twenty minutes now.
'Walked to plant'
'Took water'
'Took water to plant'
'Read article ⅓ way through innovation magazine, investigate later'
'Changed position on chair to left foot forward, likely 30% uncomfortable'
'Looked at plant' tick marks
'Spoke with Bryn'
'Eyes looked excessively left and right'
'Folded arms'
'Persuaded'
'Fake smile when parting'
"Are you okay Doctor Nulvis?" the security guard asked.
"Yes," she said, "I've established a baseline." Alyn closed the notebook and tucked it into the grey folder with Dryl's symbol on it, taking it with her as she left the security room.
"Baseline?" the guard asked the empty room.

Shortly…
Kindness Alyn told herself, sliding into the personality.
A sweet smile came to her, the clip board moved casually to her side with the grey folder. Shoulders soft… even pace, you're not in a hurry anymore. Sociable, kind, personable. You're not in charge, you're going to help her.
The new Alyn turned the corner, her expression welcoming as she approached the girl, "Flora Bloomfield?"

The girl rose and took her hand, “Hi there!” She said cheerfully and quickly, “I’m here for an interview for the Production Associate position posted on the Entrapt-net. They told me to wait here.”
Alyn tilted her head noticing the rushed words. ‘Feigning nervousness.. Interesting’ thought Alyn. “I’m so sorry that it’s taking so long. I’m Nora Torque, Alyn’s assistant. She sent me here with her apologies for running late. Won’t you come into the interview room? I think there’s some snacks there and some bottled water.”
She didn’t miss the out of pace blink the girl gave when the mention of bottled water came up. It didn’t stop the girl's voice from being bubbly, “Oh I’d love that! Maybe a little cocoa to warm up?”
Cold… she’s out of climate. ‘Nora’ hummed thoughtfully. Her painted smile turned her words bright, “I think we might be able to do something like that.”
The two entered the office. A large solid dark wood table was inside. It held around ten chairs. Long vertical windows lined one wall, offering a breathtaking view of the vast landscape below. The building, perched on the exterior of a towering mountain, gave them a bird's-eye perspective of the sprawling terrain below. Nearby Alyn walked over to a cupboard and searched through the supplies.
She glanced back, “Is peppermint okay?” In that glance she noticed that the girl was taking the seat to the right of the end of the table.
Flora shrugged, “It doesn’t matter really, just something hot.”
Alyn picked out a packet, “I think… ahh, Alyn has some Plumerian Black Gold tea here.”
Flora laughed, “I suppose my clothing gives me away?”
Alyn playfully replied, “I’d like to think of myself as pretty insightful. I’d like to be an interviewer someday myself!”
Flora smiled freely, “Well I’m an open book. Ask me anything! It will help me get ready to talk to Alyn.”
As she moved over to the water kettle Alyn / Nora painted a breath of innocence on her voice, “Okay umm… Where do you see yourself in ten years?”

“I’d like to have had a promotion in that time at some point.” said Flora, “I’d like to be a real contributor here at Cronos and… well, I’d like it if we stopped making weapons, maybe work on the farming initiatives.”
Alyn busied herself working with heating up the water for the tea. She glanced back at Flora noting that she had folded her hands on the desk. She considered if Flora was doing that on purpose to seem less threatening, comfort herself, or if she was doing it unconsciously.
Alyn brought the tea over to Flora, “Okay, how about: “What would you say your greatest weakness is?”
Flora smiled sweetly, “I know that question is really designed to tell you what I am trying to improve about myself so that you can see if Chronos can help my development. I think that I'd like to see myself better at taking compliments. Right now, I think I deflect compliments to my peers more than I take them comfortably.”
Answering a question with a question and answering the easier question… Definitely a politician's behavior.
Alyn set the tea on the table, its warm fragrances wafting into the air. It was time to hobble her. Alyn purposefully sat down across from Flora and brought the file to her. The ‘kindness’ personality of Nora left her in a flash. Alyn knew that when her smile fell, her features would sharpen, the room’s energy would change as she wrapped herself in the sterility of the concrete around her.
Alyn’s voice bristled, “Your file says that you worked at AeroFlora Agricultural Industries as a consultant to Austyn Verdant’s head of field fertility. How is Vyktoria these days?” Her eyes left ‘Flora’s’ She didn’t need to keep reading the girl when she knew the ending of this.
Flora’s digits tightend in their fold rattled by the sudden shift in ‘Nora's’ demeanor. Her voice broke, “What? Uh-Um Vyktora is fine, she’s um… Still enjoying her research into perfecting the ph-balance of the north fields on the mountain.”
Alyn had heard enough. The north fields were a control group, there was nothing to actually research there, but Vyktoria spent a lot of time thinking there because of the aesthetics, likely the spy network assumed improperly. Alyn reached into her lab coat and

produced a glock looking handgun and placed it onto the table.
Flora's eyes snapped open and she bolted to her feet in shock, fearfully she shouted, "Oh stars! What the hell are you doing!?"
Alyn's voice was stone calm, "I don't think you have any idea how much trouble you're in… Perfuma."
When the girl's eyes darted to the door Alyn verbally pointed out, "Thirty seven guards, ten security cameras, that is if you knew where you were going… That's what you'd have to get through to get to the street. The window is no better, nothing to hit for twelve thousand feet and it's a high gamble to hope for some spores in the air this time of year for you to manipulate into some kind of soft landing."
Perfuma's eyes squinted, "I only see one that I need to knock out."
Could it be? Does she still think I'm Nora? Well… she did drop her mask, I might as well mine.
Alyn looked at the papers again and flipped one over with her free hand, "I don't think you would be getting on Entrapta's good side if you… 'knocked me out' Also I think I have the superior position with my hand on a firearm."
"And that might even matter if the gun was loaded." Perfuma said.
That made Alyn lift her eyes from Perfuma's file, her head pitching subtly to the side, the slightest admiring smile on her face.
The girl explained by repeating something that she knew Alyn to say often, "I'm a doctor, I help people."
"I'm also very good at keeping people from bleeding out." she countered. She did slide the gun to the side since it was identified as a useless piece in the game. Alyn then gestured to the chair next to her at the end of the table for Perfuma to take.
"Let us then cut to the real question here. Why are you spying on Dryl? Your kingdom is in the Alliance against the Horde and has taken 'the moral high ground' in this conflict. Why stoop to this kind of behavior."
Perfuma looked guilty, clearly tussling with something on her side. She came to sit next to Alyn at the corner of the table, "It was decided that if Dryl was allied with the Horde it needed to be struck just as hard. I was sent here with a small group that was supposed to sabotage the weapons that were being made as well

as start poisoning the water supply."
All the cards really are on the table… What could she want? Alyn closed the file again, most of what was in there was being admitted right now. She asked the absurd, "So how is your operation coming along?"
"We… didn't know." the girl said.
Alyn watched her. She rapped a pencil on the grey file.
Perfuma frowned, "We didn't know that you weren't allied with the Horde in the way we thought. It is miserable here."
The doctor stated flatly, "Alright."
Perfuma said, "The insurgent group all agreed last night. We want to help you."
Alyn just said the same, "Alright."
Perfuma looked surprised, "Your people are suffering… Haven't you noticed?"
Alyn took a deep sigh, the girl was new to espionage and clearly didn't have the malicious intent that Alyn first suspected. She decided to help her with some public information, "Dryl has noticed that the economy is starting to change, this is currently attributed to the difficulties of working in a world that finds itself at war. Amenities are purposefully shrinking to make up for the fact that the demand for munitions are on the rise. It is not unexpected."
"Yes but what does that do to the average citizen?"
Alyn believed she understood the girl's motivations now. She knew Perfuma must have just encountered some isolated bad part of Dryl because her group needed to remain anonymous. Then she had assumed that it was like that everywhere. Alyn stood, "I believe my work is complete here. I was tasked with finding the spy and I have done so. It is up to the board of directors what is to be done with you now."
Perfuma rose then and quickly clasped Alyn's passing arm, "Please! Please no. If I go into that council I'm going to end up like all the other diplomats that have been sent. I need this to be different. Dryl needs this to be different."
"Special pleading." Alyn deduced with a bored tone to her voice.
"What?" Perfuma asked.
Alyn explained, "The logical fallacy you're invoking is special

pleading. You're trying to make this one case an exception to the rule for no real reason other than you especially want it."
Perfuma shook her head, "The reason is because I saw someone using a stone tool to screw in a bolt into a support girder the other day in Courtly Commons square. She couldn't find a screwdriver and had to make due. And that's just the beginning, I could give you twenty similar stories!"
Alyn's mind moved that scenario forward. If they couldn't find screwdrivers that close to the palace, how soon would it be before she had to start using some other chemical other than bleach to sterilize surgery tools. How many Dryl doctors already were?
At last she huffed, "Wait here."

Shortly…
When Alyn entered Entrapta's new office, she had to look at the door again to make sure that she was in the right spot. The old throne room was large with recessed lighting giving it a soft ambient light. A hum of electronic devices fluctuated throughout the space from various projects in partial completion. Six project tables, three on either side, lead up to a single desk at the other end of the room where there was a computer and a manual telephone that waited to be used for making direct calls. Pens were scattered on the table, they must have been disturbed by Entrapta's latest idea, some things can't change about the purple haired princess. Only the soft ambient recessed lighting was left from what was the throne room of Dryl.
Entrapta wore twin Halo headbands that Alyn thought made her look childish. A layman would think she was wearing comically big purple pigtails. The hairpieces had woven her shapeable hair into a stool to sit on while she fiddled with soldering something on a board… at least the smoke rising from the desk made her think that. She was in her purple flight suit that was littered with decorations indicating that she was now the head of defense, a special position that the board had crafted to give Entrapta powers to direct the Arms and Armory council but only in times of war.
Alyn teased, "I take it you took my suggestion to heart about compartmentalizing your projects with this layout of the throne

room, Princess."
Entrapta glanced up from what she was doing, then back. A smile came to her face realizing she just saw Alyn, "Yeah… you usually dispense pretty good advice."
Alyn walked to Entrapta's side holding her clipboard casually against herself; her own Halo ponytail swayed behind her cheerfully flicking at the tip. She took a moment to note the elements of the apparently new project that Entrapta was working on. All the other tables held prior projects in various states of success, but not this one. She noted the scrap of paper that Entrapta had begun scribbles on. It was a concept not dissimilar to a skinner box. Alyn remembered that she had talked with Entrapta earlier in the week about a particular experiment that one of her staff was working with the makeup of mouse brains. The mouse had been placed in a box with buttons to dispense food and water; but ended up starving to death because they wouldn't stop hitting a button that would activate the pleasure center of its brain. She had drummed him out of Eclypse Labs with black marks on his resume ensuring that he would never work in the sciences again.
There it was though, on Entrapta's desk. She had wanted to talk about the spy but she had to ask her, "What's this?"
Entrapta's eyes widened slightly and she reached slowly over to turn the paper over. She tried to say casually, "Something that didn't pan out."
Alyn scowled, seeing right through it, "Oh-kay. That's a lie."
Entrapta set down the pencil she was working with next to a pile of what appeared to be spices and a length of paper roll which is where the smoke was coming from, "Come on Alyn, you can't tell me a story about the brain being able to be completely controlled and not have me delve deeper. Why does this one experiment bother you when the Halo project was practically demanded by you. Both of them deal with the inner workings of the self."
Alyn gave the slightest shake of her head, "The Halos are an extension of the mind into reality controlled by the mind. The box he was making was taking something external and forcing it on the mind to a deadly end." She flipped the paper over, forcing its truths out, "And this… is some sort of chemical that does the

same thing? Based on smokeleaf?"
Entrapta rolled her eyes dismissively, "We're not mice Alyn. People would be able to break away from something so simple."
Alyn lifted her brows, "Would they? Do you know how many people have addiction problems? How many end up in remission?" She jabbed the paper, "And that's without… tripling the potency!? Entrapta!"
Entrapta drew a line, "Look! I don't come into your lab and start nosing my way into what you're doing. This might be dead in the water, okay? It has to go through many levels of vetting before it's even heard by the directors."
Alyn stared at Entrapta. Her anger about the nature of the skinner box almost made her react to her friend defending the idea. But something about what Entrapta said gave her pause. She was simply establishing a boundary. She looked ashamedly down, realizing that she was breaking her code of ethics by not respecting Entrapta's privacy here, "I'm… I'm sorry. I wasn't aware of the rules of this room."
Entrapta sighed, "No, it's okay, I should have been more clear."
A strange silence settled between them. Entrapta spoke next, "I was going to tell you, just… when it got further along and I could frame it just right."
Alyn rested a moment before letting a smile touch the side of her face, "You know, I suppose there are things that I've written down in my office that I'd rather you not see either… just most of them are from before I met you."
They locked eyes then, wordlessly forgiving each other.
Alyn spoke next, "I got to the bottom of that person infiltrating Chronos."
Entrapta lifted off her hair-stool and smiled, "Oh? I take it they're in custody then?"
Alyn shook her head, "She's just a kid from Plumeria… who happens to be their princess."
Entrapta gave a thoughtful frown and said, "Well then, I look forward to seeing her before the directors." When Alyn didn't change her expression, Entrapta quizzically pitched her head.
Alyn explained, "I think it's best if she explains what she's doing here."

Entrapta reframed it just to make sure she understood, "A spy, convinced you to let them talk to me?"
Alyn gave the slightest nod of her head.
Entrapta gave an exaggerated nod indicating that she would hear Perfuma.

Later…
Perfuma got up when Entrapta entered the room. The girl extended her hand but the engineer walked right past her, "Alright!" blustered Entrapta, "So what am I doing here?" she asked Alyn who came behind her. They were sliding into a kind of act that they had used before. Before Alyn could reply, Entrapta pointed at the glock style gun, "You left her here with a gun? A gun?"
Perfuma came to Alyn's defense pointing out, "An unloaded gun."
Entrapta grasped the firearm, "What this unloaded gun?" She popped out the full clip letting it clatter from the device to the table and then expertly ejected the loaded bullet from the chamber. It tumbled harmlessly over her shoulder to somewhere else in the room.
When terror washed over Perfuma's face it made Entrapta's eyes crinkle, the fine lines at the corner of her lips deepened in a wide smile. She reached across the table to take Perfuma's hand in a firm handshake. She decided to flip the polarity of the room yet again, "Princess Entrapta here, those are rubber bullets. On special request of the king of Brightmoon, we just landed a contract with the Hierophant Alliance to begin producing non-lethal munitions last week. Let me tell you, it really is difficult turning a killing machine into a stunning machine but we have a lot of ideas we're kicking around. It's kinda fun if I say so."
Poor Perfuma quivered and put her head in her hands, "Please I just want to explain my proposal."
Entrapta relaxed, putting her boots on the table casually and prompted, "Go for it."
Perfuma blinked a few times, gathering her proposal that she had in order mentally a few moments ago. A steadying breath escaped her, another before Entrapta kicked her feet off the table and stood up.

Perfuma's voice pleaded, "Wait! Please, you have to listen to this. I'm just… very unsure of who I'm dealing with right now."
Entrapta looked to Alyn who gave a calm nod of her head, it meant that the cage-rattling was over.
Entrapta settled back into the chair letting her bluster fall away. She spoke genuinely, "You're dealing with Entrapta, Princess of Dryl. A woman who had every right to rule the kingdom she was born into but had those powers stripped from her before her parents were taken by the Horde. That same organization moves freely through her kingdom and would squash this little city without a second thought if not for our ability to produce high quality firearms. They can't work our factories, only our specialists can do that… and those same people are willing to lay down their lives to keep our sovereignty from any nation. What are you proposing, flower girl?"
Entrapta unpacking her situation gave Perfuma time to collect herself again. She began, "I've been living inside Dryl for a few months now. We started our operation holed up in a hotel just outside of the palace walls. What we came to do quickly became apparent that we couldn't follow through with. We contacted our superiors and explained how little the people had out there."
The engineer glanced over to Alyn, then back to Perfuma. The girl kept going, "When we realized the depth of poverty settling into Dryl, our mission evolved. We pivoted to smuggling in crucial tools, medicine, and supplies from Plumeria. It became clear that our actions were stabilizing the city, providing essential relief to its suffering inhabitants. The people desperately needed these supplies. As the operation continued some of the local law enforcement started to pick up on what we were doing. We've had brushes with them but it has become very apparent that we needed to know that this is an okay thing for us to continue doing. We need some kind of covert approval of this that we could show the local police… maybe a kind of black ops authorization? The law enforcement said that you would be the one to talk with about that."
Entrapta thinned her lips again, she looked to Alyn to interpret. Alyn condensed, "So, if what she says is true, I think it's wise for us to accept this aid."

Entrapta shrugged, "So let's do it. I'll get together some kind of infrared badge or something and seed out to the enforcement that individuals bearing this mark are not to be arrested or are only to be held a short time before release." Entrapta pointed to Perfuma then, "I'm going out on a limb here with this. We never had this meeting. I don't know who you are, Perfuma."
Perfuma took her shot by urgently asking, "We… could be much more effective in this if you were to publicly endorse the Alliance. We could protect Dryl, we could get Brightmoon and Snows soldiers inside your city walls within weeks."
Entrapta echoed, "Weeks." She looked to the side and shivered her head no, "If you can make that hours? Then we can talk. The horde black seed transports might not be able to deliver a legion of soldiers but they can release enough monsters they've made with their own version of 'Chimera' that we would be in tatters within two days. You can bet that they would do that in an instant if we didn't have them over the barrel like we do right now. Just look what happened to Ly-" She stopped dead in her tracks realizing Alyn was still in the room with them. She rephrased, "They've done terrible things to us already."
Perfuma gazed sadly down.
Entrapta encouraged, "I… wish I had the backing and courage you do, Perfuma. Dryl law enforcement won't get in your way. We can make sure of that."

Four months later…
Three figures gathered around the tube television displaying the drone footage. The black and white images were zoomed in and grainy, flickering, but their imagery could be nothing else. Isabella had her hand on Entrapta's shoulder, Alyn's hand on the other. Entrapta had her mouth covered with her hands. Alyn held her clipboard close. Tears rolled down Entrapta's cheeks. The video looped again.
The video was completely silent, but clearly showed a car moving down a road at a steady pace but was brutally smashed by a Horde convoy truck which immediately swarmed out troops.
A few people sprang out of the wreckage and started to weakly run but bright laser fire from the convoy soldiers made the

civilians twist in shock and crumple as they were exterminated one by one. The last one in the car desperately scrambled under the tangle of fire and chassis. Her grainy body twisted once, twice from being struck by blasts of light. Then the two vehicles lurched as a wild tree ruptured from the ground but stopped in mid rise as a final burst of light stopped the last passenger.
Isabella quietly stated the obvious, "Nobody else makes trees rise from the ground like that, Entrapta."
Entrapta looked up at Alyn who was arching her brows and sadly wagging her head in shock.
She looked back to the video ending with the lead soldier motioning for others to gather around before it looped back to the car approaching again to be culled all over again.
Entrapta croaked, "I… I did this, I killed that girl."
Alyn urged, "Entrapta, no… no you didn't. You weren't in that caravan."
Entrapta threw off Alyn's hand, "No! But they were only there because of how terrible I am as a leader. I invited the Horde inside our borders. I'm supplying them with weapons."
Alyn's clip board fell to the floor as she grabbed Entrapta's shoulders shaking them, "You're not a murderer though! That truck assaulted someone that knew what they were getting into. She knew the risks and did it anyway."
She threw back Alyn's hands, "I could have told her to go home, forget all about this. But no, I saw an opportunity to make a hero, to create a real connection with the Alliance even if it was covert. I wanted to see hope!" Entrapta shook her head turning to the side while looking back at the repeating video, "But that's not for me… is it?"
Alyn leaned down to scoop her clipboard back up. Alyn urgently pressed, "There's always hope, Entrapta."
Entrapta balled a fist up to her lips just shaking her head, her red eyes glancing to either side. Entrapta's eyebrows drifted down into a dark scowl, "They're pushing us, Alyn… They're only stoking the fire of something that can't be stopped."

Chapter 14: Age 33

Chapter Summary

Entrapta's relentless drive to push Project Ares from animal testing to human trials reaches a critical juncture. Alyn, deeply concerned about the potential consequences and determined to prevent a catastrophe, decides to use the 'failsafe disk' entrusted to her for such an emergency. This pivotal moment escalates into a dramatic confrontation in the waiting room outside her office, where the power dynamics between the two friends come to a head. As Entrapta passionately defends her vision and the necessity of the experiment, Alyn stands firm in her resolve to stop it. The chapter explores themes of ambition, ethics, and the strain on their friendship, creating a tense and emotionally charged narrative. Readers are left on the edge of their seats, eager to see whether Entrapta can persuade Alyn to abandon her plan or if it is already too late, making this chapter a must-read.

Eternal dystopia mix -

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_gEum9d8AxU&list=RDCMUCJUPRD_SneWvoKaMBIUNiFg&index=4

She had to. There wasn't any other choice, nobody was stopping her. She looked down at the special token. Back into the pocket it went. It was the last hours before the next phase of the experiment was going to be pushed forward. She never expected the board to even listen to her friend, let alone give her more than the funding than she was asking for. This was madness. It had to be stopped.

She stepped into the lab. The project supervisor was helping one of the assistants in front of a mouse cage. He got up and took a few steps to get close to Alyndrah, "Can we help you, Director?"

Her fingers went cold as she pinched the special token in her pocket, chewing on her lip nervously, heart thrashing. Barry put a hand on her shoulder, "Doctor?"

There was no going back, this would save thousands. It would keep everyone alive. She pulled out her hand and showed the coin to the supervisor. He raised his brows and nodded, "I- I understand."

As Alyn tucked the coin back into her lab coat Barry turned to the assistant explaining, "Sterilize the animals, the project is being scrapped."

The young student gasped, "But Sir!"

Barry shook his head, "No questions, just do it. Shredding documents is next."

Alyn felt a tremor move through her when fear clutched her heart. The supervisor quickly moved over to his desk and started gathering paperwork together swiftly into a basket.

The assistant stared at her. Alyn forced stoic confidence on her face though she was quivering inside, unsure what the future would hold for Dryl with this action. The assistant's will crumbled first in the stare-off and she silently, perhaps sadly, picked up the cage with the animal in it, taking it over to the nearest fume hood.

Alyn tightened her grip on her clip-board pulling it close to her chest in comfort seeing the animal go in. She heard the supervisor punch a communicator on his desk starting to delegate orders to other supervisors in the R&D wing. Now that she was sure that things were moving swiftly she turned on her flats and started out the door, heading for the Director's office.

Shortly…

Alyn paced back and forth in the waiting room. She had redirected the secretary to assist with the restructuring that would have to follow project termination. Alyndrah hated the clammy feeling in her palms and neck, the gentle breeze of moving back and forth in the waiting room helped. Nothing seemed to be coming to her, what was she going to say? What would make things better? Part of her pondered a gaslighting tactic but it was immediately pushed away, she couldn't condition Entrapta into thinking something that wasn't her. If she did, she'd be no better than what Entrapta was trying to do.

The door to the director's office opened. Entrapta's long hair swayed behind her in those two huge ponytails, her flight suit was off her shoulders today, brazenly showing off her white tank top. The sleeves of her suit were knotted around her waist. A sheen of sweat glowed on her forehead and chest as she entered the room. The stress of the project clearly was pounding on Entrapta.

"Nancy? Where are the reports that should be coming in from-?" Entrapta's eyes finally registered that the secretary desk was empty. She turned her eyes to the liminal space of the waiting room and caught sight of Alyndrah turning to face her.

Entrapta's shoulders tightened with anxiety. She forced her voice to be calm when she asked, "Where… Where are the project supervisors Alyn? They should be here-…" She licked her drying lips, "They should be here submitting their final reports to Nancy, Alyn…"

Alyn tightened her lips and walked towards Entrapta. A remorseful crease formed on her face.

Anger cut into Entrapta's voice, "Where are the *people* Alyn!?"

Alyn almost wailed, "You *can't do* it Entrapta! We can't start implementing government authorized addictions to-"

Entrpata threw up her hands, "Oh no-… oh no no no no! NO!" she shoved Alyn back when she got close, "You filed ten complaints to the board of directors! They reviewed each one and said that they were unfounded or acceptable losses."

Alyn threw her own hand to the side, shouting through bared teeth, "Government authorized addiction to raise an army!? Entrapta! You can't do it!"

Entrapta shouted louder, "We're not even at that stage yet!! We're simply moving from animal to human testing!"

Alyn shouted right back, "And what about those people that trust us and our research! They're volunteering for something that is going to have lifelong consequences!"

Entrapta shoved her friend's shoulder, "How the hell can you know that!? We've only been working on it for a year! Oh wait! That's right!" Entrapta patted her chest, "I'm the only one that has been working on this and I've put everything into it. You're just watching and trying to derail my research with your damn ethics when we're watching the damned horde choke the life from us!" Entrapta broke their eye to eye shouting match and reached for her secretary's desk. She slapped papers around looking for something. It didn't stop Alyn from shouting at Entrapta's back, "Our *ethics* are what makes us different from the damn horde! Hordak did horrific things to his people when the spies told him about project Chim-"

Entrapta found the paper she was looking for and snatched it from the desk. It was thrust into Alyn's face, cutting off her statement. Entrapta nearly screamed at her, "Sixteen today!!"

Alyn blinked, confused and then stepped back starting to protest, "wh-"

Entrapta didn't let her retreat. She got into Alyn's space again shaking the paper, "Sixteen people died today because we can't defend our people! Something has to change! An army of our own

can do that for us!" Entrapta furiously threw the paper to the side which spiraled to the floor.

Alyn looked up and sighed, "Entrapta…"

"NO!" Entrapta curtly shouted back, "Don't you start twisting this into some kind of psychological excavation of why I'm behaving the way I am! What's it going to be this time? My parents didn't love me enough!? I'm making up for inferiority complexes? I was abused as a child? I'm paranoid!?"

Alyn looked down sadly, she felt the token in her pocket and brought it out slowly. Entrapta spied it and looked up and around in exasperation. Alyn was back to looking at Entrapta's back again.

Alyn simply said, "This is it, this is what you told me that I would be looking for. It's wrong. And you know it."

Entrapta pinched the bridge of her nose, having trouble controlling her anger.

They stayed like that for a long moment.

Entrapta finally spoke softly, not looking at the doctor, "I… gave that to you, because I trusted you… above everyone else."

Alyn closed the space with her friend again. Alyn took a hand off her clipboard and rested it gently on Entrapta's damp back. She mirrored Entrapta's change in tone to quiet, "I know, stars I know. I'm only using it because you're on the edge, Entrapta. You're ready to bullet ahead to a place that's so dark and you're not thinking clearly about it."

Entrapta said, "Alyn… if you do this-..." She chewed on her tongue a moment jutting out her jaw. She tried explaining, "We are *hours* away from taking this to the next phase of testing. Stopping now would mean thousands of wasted hours. Hundreds of gallons of chemicals would have to be destroyed, we're building a whole assembly line in Chronos to refine the chemicals, pill

casings, careers are going to be scrapped because of this one action you're talking about taking."

Alyn conveyed that she knew all this by simply saying, "More like… forty five minutes now."

Entrapta laughed at the absurdity of it. She tilted her head back and faced Alyn again. The motion made Alyn's hand trail over to Entrapta's shoulder. The princess' expression was plain, perhaps trying to call her bluff, "Fine… go put it in the computer." She gestured to the director's office.

Alyndrah tightened her cheeks feeling the sting of tears in her eyes. She whispered, "I'm sorry." before she paced quickly to the door and pushed through.

The high windows filtered in light down below, passing over Alyn as she moved through the space. Alyn's flat shoes took her over the low blue carpet and to the simple terminal. She inserted the coin-like disk into the computer and almost immediately sparks flew shorting out the drive inside. Signals were automatically sent to the other servers in the building to also burn out their drives. Alyn stared at the blank screen, a little stunned herself that she just did that to Entrapta. The purple haired woman slowly followed after, there's no rush now. Alyn watched her approach, a part of her on high alert, she tightened her grip on her clipboard holding it close. Entrapta took out a stick of the Ares drug and popped it into her mouth. She flicked a lighter on lighting up her face orange behind cupped hands. The end of the stick lit and she breathed in the chemical as she snapped closed the lighter. She came to a rest putting her rump on the edge of the dark wood desk next to the smoking computer and Alyndrah.

Entrapta said with finality, "I'm not making another one of those… ever again."

Alyn looked down, then pushed her browline glasses up on her face again, "I… I understand. I can start looking for a new leader of Eclypse La-."

Entrapta smirked, shaking her head, “No no… not like that.”

Alyn tilted her head slightly in curiosity.

Entrapta took another drag to calm her frustrations, then spoke through smoke, “This isn’t about pushing you out. If you go, that's your own choice, you’re not a prisoner here. This is about removing your ‘no’s. All the stuff that’s in the way of your greatness.”

Alyn puffed air out her nose, partly because of the smell of the smoke, partly as a scoff, “I am a medical, research, and clinical doctor not to mention my recent doctorate of psychology… and you want to see me reach even higher?”

Entrapta got a smile on her face and looked at Alyn over her shoulder, “Yeah… in a word. As long as there’s a horizon, we should reach for it. If there’s something saying ‘No’ we should immediately ask, ‘Why?’ Not, ‘You’re right. Let’s stop here.’”

Alyn shook her head, “And so we fall off the mountain because we’re too exhausted from hanging on by our fingertips.”

Entrapta shook her head, speaking strongly, “That’s part of asking ‘Why?’ Listening! But you’re too terrified to even do that.”

Alyn frowned sadly at Entrapta, sticking to the ultimate truth she knew, “You were going to ruin lives.”

Entrapta countered, “Lives were going to be ruined either way today. It’s just my way, there was going to be something to show for it in the end.” She sighed and pushed off the table to pace around. She glanced over at the switchboard next to the hardwire telephone lighting up like a holiday tree. She chewed on the Aries stick then roughly yanked the cord on the device, “So what now?”

Alyn risked looking at Entrapta, “You’re not… mad?”

Entrapta huffed a laugh, “I’m *furious!* I’m probably not going to sleep tonight. I’m going to have to explain this to Warren and

everyone else on the board of directors, I'm going to have to figure out how to return all the investor money. Don't get me started on Evelyn and Isabella!" Entrapta chortled at the overwhelming magnitude of how much trouble she was in, "There's so much work to do… but I'd like something to look forward to."

Alyn asked meekly, "You still want to work with me?"

Entrapta nodded as she took the stick out of her mouth and put out the ember in an ashtray on the table. She said, "Yeah, I can tell that you were only doing what you thought was right." Another laugh escaped her, "Plus, you're fresh out of fail-safe tokens, so the next thing that we take on won't have that limitation."

Alyn's green eyes widened realizing her world is a lot less safe than before.

Entrapta asked, "So…" She folded her arms, "What do you want to work on?"

Alyn asked, "Will people trust us after all this? When it comes out what the project was…"

Entrapta laughed again, "Alyn… I'm an engineer. I make stuff that makes things easier. You're a doctor, you help people. The people are in the grips of despair from the pressure the Horde is putting on us. I think they'll see this for what it was. Since our intentions were good, I think it should all come out in the wash."

Alyn desperately searched Entrapta's face trying to coax out what on Etheria she might want from her. Impossibly, something murmured in the shadows of her mind replying, *'Something that will fix this, something that will make us both smile.'*

Alyn's voice delicately repeated it, "Something that will make us both smile."

The purple haired woman's eyes fluttered, "That's-... yeah, just what I was thinking."

Alyn volunteered, "What… What about something like Project Halo. Remember how we both loved working on the Halo project?"

Entrapta wagged her finger, "Y'know, what if we worked on something next quarter that worked using the Halo system of controlling our hair and applied it to cybernetics. Sure we have the mastery of DNA, but we can't regrow limbs just yet. Robotics could help medicine there."

Alyn let a warm grin come to her face. That same soft murmur assured her that the smile she was receiving from Entrapta was completely genuine. Something about it told her how warm Entrapta was towards her right now in this chaotic time. Her ability to read people already told her this but something deeper was speaking to her. Something she couldn't quite place.

Chapter 15: Age 34

Chapter Summary

In this pivotal chapter, Alyn and Entrapta push the boundaries of science and ethics as they achieve a groundbreaking technological breakthrough, merging biology and technology in ways never before imagined. But the excitement of their success quickly gives way to darker consequences. Alyn's internal conflict intensifies as she grapples with the moral implications of their work, culminating in a chilling decision to requisition human brain tissue for further experiments. As the project escalates, tensions rise within the Dryl leadership, leading to a confrontation that threatens to unravel the very fabric of their society. Alyn's desperate desire to make Entrapta smile again pushes her down a path of dangerous ambition, where the line between visionary innovation and ethical collapse blurs beyond recognition.

Push the envelope. That's what the lab was talking about these days, pushing the envelope, going to the edge.

A smile threatened to show itself on Alyn's lips. Her browline glasses reflected the flat tube monitor. The visual showed that three bits of information went in. The air was tense.

They sat at Alyn's desk. There was a little jar to their right filled with a red opaque liquid with something barely visible inside. Light forced its way through the murky viscous fluid. Alyn sat on the chair, next to her Entrapta, their faces illuminated in the dim light, the engineer's hand on her shoulder.

"Come on." Entrapta said hopefully

As if that was all it was waiting for, the three packets of information were recalled to the main system.

The two of them screamed. Alyn shot to her feet, her chair clattering away making a short succession of three tumbles. Excitedly, they embraced jumping around in circles. They exchanged a brief hug, then held each other by the arms locking eyes. Alyn's white teeth shone in the dark and she brought her hand to her face laughing, "I can't believe it!" Alyn's stuttering chuckle finished echoing on the walls of the lab and she realized that Entrapta was watching her. A strange silence settled in that moment but before it could be named, Entrapta looked over to the boxy computer and chopped her hand at it. "Well I can!" Entrapta grabbed the monitor and gave it a happy smooch, "We've made history here! Truly a complete bridge of biology and technology! We just stored three packets of digital information inside a mouse brain and then had it recall! This means that with a few more refinements we could literally hook someone up to a computer!"

Alyn's eyes watered, a crash of thoughts were shoving themselves together. One part of her mind was screaming with sorrow that she had a hand in building something so terribly wrong, the other was weeping with joy that her friend was smiling again. She barked out a confused noise.

Entrapta was tapping away at the console but looked up when Alyn repeated that same coughing sound that might've been a sob. Entrapta had to make two attempts to rise out of the numbers rolling on the screen. She looked at Alyn like she was some kind of alien. Entrapta stammered, "What the f-... What? Are you crying?"

Alyn wanted to do a hundred things all in that same moment but she chose to lie, "I'm just happy, so happy."

https://youtu.be/Qhlt4td3bZQ?si=dTz_V51T4qzIzfga&t=122

Entrapta's manic expression was there in her space again. Her friend squeezed her shoulders, "I'm gonna go get Orion and show

him! I'm so excited to see where this leads!"

Alyn nodded behind her loosely clutched hand over her lips. Entrapta ran off at impressive speed, step-vaulting by Halo pigtails.

Alyn, now alone, righted the tumbled chair and rolled up to the softly glowing monitor. Her fingers dashed along the keyboard but it was too late. Entrapt-net storage was too efficient. The data was now stored in the network, if she deleted it from here it would make no difference, it would only show that she *tried* to delete it. A sob trembled out of her again as her cracked mind conjured a horrific vision. She knew that human brain tissue was far more complex and used to working with strange analog problems. A human brain wouldn't even have to be alive to do the storage and recall of information. Not only that, they could run data retrieval in parallel, blasting fiberoptic processors out of the water as far as complex problem solving. The whole thing could be created into a kind of server farm, the dead could be used to serve the living.

Her sobs stuttered again as a giddy laugh came up. Entrapta would *love* the idea. *She* would be the reason her friend smiled more. More manic laughs came to her, tears still ran down her cheeks. She cradled the monitor in her quaking fingers, lovingly pressing her lips right where Entrapta's were.

She hissed a sharp gasp. Her dissociated voice rose in her throat naming their child, "Prooject He-Heaven!" her shrill cackle echoed in her office.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q6wDm9C5YEo

Days later…

Barry burst into her office. Alyn looked dubiously at him and set down the silverware at her desk.

“I’ve got a problem with this *requisition* you’ve issued.” He said.

“What is the problem?” Alyn asked, remaining polite.

“This amount of human brain tissue would need thirty corpses at least. Where the hell are we going to get that?” the man was flabbergasted, “This has to be a joke, right? What on earth are you working on Alyn?”

Her eyes looked down, lips tightened.

He blustered, “You’ve been spending too much time with that maniac princess. *She’s* asking for this isn’t she? She probably wants to do more ballistics testing and isn’t satisfied with wasting pig analogs anymore.”

Alyn simply took her napkin and started to dab at her tightened lips.

“You can tell me, Alyn, please. If you’re stuck or being threatened by her, you *can* reach out to the other council members. We don’t have to just blindly follow her!”

She rose up, discarding the napkin to her lunch plate. Alyn's blonde ponytail slid over her shoulder like a snake. Her scowling presence made the man’s complaints die in his throat.

Her piercing green eyes looked right through him. She coldly said, “You don’t hear her like I do, do you? You don’t hear the feelings of sadness when she cheerfully says hello to the board of directors. You don’t hear her mind burst into tears when someone talks about their mother’s toasty cookies. Or how they are looking forward to spending time with their dad that night.”

She tapped her Halo hair band with one of her hands. She reached for his shoulder with the other, while her hair grasped at his shoulder. “I will be the one to banish those dark thoughts, I will be the one to bring her joy again.”

Bary couldn't make the connection about what Alyn was talking about, “The joy of brain tissue?”

Alyn heard herself giggling, “Yes!” she said excitedly, “The joy that I will bring her, with all this brain tissue! You *do* understand!” Her teeth chattered as she grabbed his face, “Now you go to the coroner and you give him this requisition. You tell him it’s direct from the Arms and Armor division and if he doesn’t want the military to take over his business he will produce those thirty bodies when they come in.”

Barry nodded, desperate suddenly to get out of Alyn’s presence. Alyn’s brow furrowed, “You’re scared… why?”

Bary lamely made up an excuse sweating under his employer’s grip, “Oh! Uhm, I’m just scared that I left the oven on this morning and I sure would like to get to a phone to tell my loving wife about it.”

She released him, “Well then, make sure that you give her a call before you head over to the office of the coroner.”

Barry skittered out of the office.

https://youtu.be/q6wDm9C5YEo?si=ScvRsuJ5oRPz5KCC&t=195

Months later

Alyn kept watching Entrapta while the papers of her project were handed out. A delicate smile held on her face.

They were in the board of directors room again. Alyn was passing out the papers that contained her special project. Entrapta looked at her again, catching the admiring smile. She gave a little chuckle, “You okay Alyn? You’re starting to look like one of the Horde diplomats.”

Her voice cheerfully replied, “I’m just so happy about what we’ve done here. The blood, the tears we’ve shed to make this our

greatest triumph. I'm so happy I get to work with you. I'm looking forward to double what we've put together."

Entrapta laughed, "I mean, yeah it is pretty amazing if you can get around what went into the project."

Alyn laughed, she heard the displeasure in Entrapta's mind about using corpses, "They're dead, Entrapta. And not only that, the tissue itself was woven together into cubes, there's nothing left of the original person in there. It's just an amazing machine that has nearly limitless applications."

Entrapta stared out across the table at Warren, a defeated look on her face.

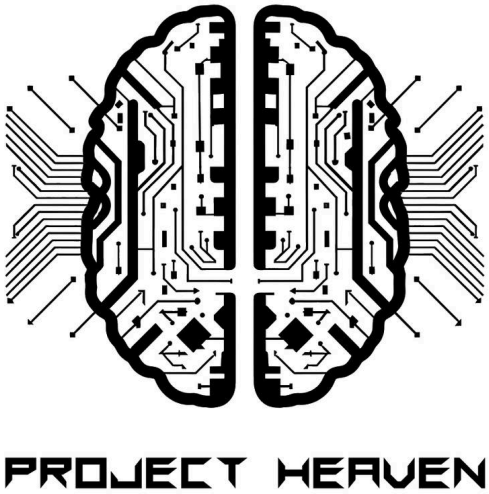
Alyn replied to Entrapta's thoughts, "Well that's a first, usually I'm the one reigning you in."

Entrapta frowned and commented, "Okay it's getting really spooky when you do that."

Alyn reminded her as Warren clacked the gavel that would start the meeting, "I'm just picking up on your nonverbal cues."

Warren looked over the folder. He flashed Entrapta and Alyn a smile from across the table, "This is different for you two. Usually your project names have some kind of clever codename. Project 2257 doesn't really roll off the tongue. Anyhow, we bring this meeting to order to evaluate a project idea brought forth by Eclypse Labs with Doctor Alyndra Nulvis MD, PHD, PsyD, EngD presenting. You have the floor Doctor Nulvis.

Alyn took to her feet her smile controlled, creasing the corners of her mouth, "Esteemed board members. Allow me to introduce to you the most significant advancement in cybernetics that me and my esteemed colleague Entrapta have done to date. I present: Project Heaven!



Alyn gestured behind her, a projector lit up showing off the animated logo for the project that they've been working on. "Project heaven redefines the nature of life itself making use of a resource that we have all too abundantly today in this war torn world we find ourselves in, the deceased."

Entrapta saw that more than one of the board members brought their hands to their face hearing that. It made her scrunch her brows.

Alyn could sense the shift in Entrapta's mood. She didn't have to worry though. They came up with it together, it made them both happy, how could it be wrong? The board just needed to listen with an open mind and they would come around by the end of it.



Alyn's eyes widened as an urgency came to her voice, "Yes!" Alyn tapped a device to advance to the next slide showing off a group of people turned horizontal on one side of the slide, and a server box on the other, "Eclypse labs has developed the technology to take tissue no longer being used by the living and reforging it into a *massive* storage system. We are on the brink of re-weaving this refuse into quantum computing, making use of human brain tissue into a processor that not only can problem solve, but can anticipate what the user might want. Everyone's Emily assistant can help them throughout the day, but Heaven could give someone a personal assistant that learns your routine and anticipates what you might need."

Alyn clicked her slide advancer, in the brief moment of darkness she saw a snapshot of the pale shock on everyone's face. It clutched her that the presentation wasn't changing their view just yet. Her words caught in her throat. "Ah-um… Our current server farm makes use of sixteen…" Alyn heard someone retch but couldn't tell who because of the shine of light in her eyes. She looked up at what was being shown, clean pink cubes were illustrated being housed inside glass and metal containers. "Sixteen th-... thought chambers…"

"That's enough Alyn." She heard Warren say.

The lights rose in the meeting room. Alyn looked forward to the lead director. Tears rolled over her cheeks. She had to at least ask, "We're asking for the funding to expand our existing-"

" *Enough!* " Warren sternly warned. Alyn looked down. She wanted to look over at Entrapta but fear for how shocked she might be ruled that out.

The silence was painful, but Warren finally said, "We-... we are in adjournment. Alyn, I will talk with you and Entrapta outside."

Alyn felt her hand clasped. She looked down at Entrapta who was giving her an encouraging smile. The doctor somehow managed to delicately smile back.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GdxbXcPYIC0&list=RDCMUCJUPRD_SneWvoKaMBIUNiFg&index=5




Dr. Alyndrah Nulvis, PHD, MD, PsyD
Director of Eclypse Labs


Entrapta Phyllipina
Princess of Dryl, Director of
Chronos Manufacturing
Age 34

The antechamber outside the meeting room was stark. Light came from the windows casting shadows on the history carvings in the concrete. Warren walked the length of the wall while Alyn stood next to Entrapta. It was rare for them to see him outside the meeting room. Out here, he was tall and broad shouldered, but not as large as he was inside. His business suit skirted the line of a military peacoat with the three geared symbol of Dryl pinned on his left. His hair was a mix of grey and dark that had a gentle wave away from his temples. His face was flushed red with anger rubbing at his forehead. His eyebrows were filled and arced into a scowl. They only got to catch one side of his expression at a time when he switched directions along the wall.

Warren's voice was deliberately restrained, "So, you have a server room made out of human flesh? Am I understanding that?"

Alyn looked ashamedly down. The stark way that Warren put it weighed heavily on her. She asked herself *'How did I let things get so out of hand? I've let Entrapta down, I've let everyone down. I was a good person before this.'*

It was Entrapta that stepped forward and spoke first. She set her jaw firmly and she said the truth she knew, "No."

Warren pointed back at the meeting room, "Then what was Alyn talking about? Because the presentation sure the hell made it look like you were using people's minds to become some kind of computer."

Entrapta stood tall as she could, then her Halo hair bands raised her taller than her stature would normally allow, "That is not the case Warren, shut up and listen." Her finger pointed in his redding face, "What we did here was a *triumph* and I won't have you turn this into a problem of ethics, do you hear me?"

The two stared knives at each other. Entrapta cut first, "It is human cranial tissue that has been reconstituted into those chambers. It is not brains in boxes, it's the re-worked material that the minds once were. They were corpses, they had no use of

that material anymore, if we didn't take that material for this project it was just going to be incinerated."

Warren gestured wide, "Like our traditions demand!"

Entrapta shouted at him, "And what an absolute *waste* that would have been. Don't you *see* that?"

Warren bellowed right back, "Are you even listening to yourself!? Did the families consent to this use of their loved ones?"

Entrapta scoffed and rolled her eyes giving Alyn the chance to interject, "Of course, you're right Warren. Don't fight with Entrapta, it was my idea that she latched on to."

Both of them looked at her. Warren fuming, Entrapta shocked. Alyn chose Entrapta, "Well!? Wasn't it my idea?"

Entrapta sputtered, "That's not the point here, Warren is not giving us the space to do innovative work!"

Alyn ignored the protest, "Senior Director, I would like to submit my resignation over this. It was simply something that got out of hand when I didn't see the implications of what was happening. It was a blind spot in my judgment, but that is no excuse."

Entrapta knifed in before Warren could speak, "That is not acceptable, Alyn. You are an essential part of project Chimera. Chimera is the only other source of income for Dryl aside from Horde contracts."

Alyn balked, "Entrapta, we used *people* to make a computer storage system-"

"DEAD People!" Entrapta corrected loudly.

She got into Entrapta's face, "It *doesn't matter* . Entrapta, this is *over* . Who in their right mind would come to me for medical screening for Chimera now? All they will be thinking about is if they're going to end up as some science experiment!"

Entratpa brought her fist to her forehead, then turned to the side, "We could silence the board, make it a classified project… tell them that the wrong presentation happened in there and the paperwork got shuffled around-"

Warren gasped and said loudly, "I'm *right here* !"

Entrapta waved him off, "I'm head of defense and can dismiss any board members that don't adhere to classified project protocols."

Warren shouted, "NO. That is an abuse of power and I won't stand for it, Entrapta. If she doesn't step down as a director then I will tender *my* resignation."

Entrapta's eyes widened, "So it's either the visionary or the fearful? I think we both know what I will choose."

Warren shivered with rage, directed it back to Alyn, "You've doomed Dryl with this." He gestured to Entrapta, " *She's* in charge now. Good luck."

Alyn took a trembling breath, it all happened so fast. Warren's footsteps stomped into the distance and he slammed the door. Entrapta stared at the exit for a beat, then looked over to Alyn who was already looking at her. The pressure on Alyn to say something was unbearable. Alyn wanted her to say something that would make things better. Somewhere, somehow, an idea slid into her head on what to say, "He is a high ranking official of Dryl. He has to stay here or else our enemies will gain a significant advantage with what he knows."

Entrapta suggested, "We should silence him."

Alyn felt her stomach flip at the idea, "Silence him? Like… execute him?"

Entrapta didn't want to answer.

Alyn desperately and quickly came up with an alternative, "No… no it's too likely he would become a martyr then. Let's just watch

to see what he does, if he tries to leave Dryl then we would be forced to take action. It's hard to immortalize a fleeing coward."

Entrapta tapped at her lips still deep in thought. Alyn came close and said softly, "I'm so sorry Entrapta. I should have said something sooner, it's just-... I wanted you to smile."

Entrapta regarded Alyn, she asked, "Don't I smile anymore?"

Alyn shook her head, "Not like when we were working on Halo… or Chimera. I just thought that if I pushed the envelope like you said, it would make things like they were."

Entrapta looked back to the door where Warren left. When no response came from Entratpa Alyn tried to coax words from her another way, "Is that really why you wanted me to stay? Project Chimera needs me to screen people who want to use it?"

She broke her staring contest with the inanimate object, her red gaze intense, "Alyn… I need you now, more than ever. You seem to be the only person choosing what to do from the angle of becoming greater instead of from a fear mentality. You're the only one I trust these days." Entrapta's intensity dropped, her lips twitched, deepening the lines there, "Nobody is more important than you."

Alyn let herself smile then, she let one of her hands leave her clipboard. She looked down watching herself hold Entrapta's hand in her's. The engineer's palm remained relaxed but didn't pull away.

Chapter 16: Age 35

Chapter Summary

In the final chapter of Project Gemini, Entrapta and Alyn's friendship faces its greatest challenge as the siege on Dryl intensifies. With their city on the brink of starvation, the two brilliant scientists launch a bold competition to solve the crisis. But as desperation deepens, the lines between innovation and disaster blur, forcing both of them to confront difficult choices with irreversible consequences.

As tensions rise and old loyalties are tested, Entrapta must grapple with the weight of her decisions, questioning not only her role as a leader but the cost of survival itself. In a world driven by war and scarcity, the very people she tried to protect may turn against her—and the outcome of Project Gemini could be far darker than she ever imagined.

In this harrowing conclusion, the story delves into themes of friendship, guilt, and the limits of human ingenuity. The stakes are higher than ever, and as the final chapter unfolds, Entrapta will discover whether she has the strength to face the consequences of her actions—or if those consequences will break her entirely.

Thank you to all the readers!

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ivsuMJLhYI8

Entrapta's steel toed black boots crunched some stray leaves that had found their way to the barren Courtly Commons Square. Few people were here this early in the morning. Shadows were long across the center clearing. The autumn sun was struggling to rise over the horizon. Their breath puffed in the chill weather. Entrapta wore a thick functional coat walking casually in stride with Alyn. The doctor had chosen a long grey puffy thing. They

each had their hair wrapped around their throats as a kind of scarf.

"This place used to have so many people." Alyn observed, "The siege seems to be working."

Entrapta thought about how this was only the first month of the entrenchment that the Horde had set up for the city. They had given the city several decrees indicating their intent. The result was a huge exodus from the city, about a quarter of the population remained. The rest had fled or became Horde prisoners depending on their level of involvement with production. Many of the board members had stopped showing up to meetings in response to Warren withdrawing from council last year. Each had members of the Dryl police force openly watching what they did from day to day now.

The engineer thought out loud, "It kind-of helps though, in a weird way. The people here now are the only ones that we can really trust. We're all here together."

The two meandered around the outside of the mostly empty square, heading towards some patio furniture and a quaint coffee shop that they had been frequenting. Alyn asked, "What do you think they're going to do with us, once the siege breaks us?"

Entrapta looked surprised, " *Once* it breaks us?" She gave a mirthless laugh, "Don't you have any faith in the Alliance? Any day now they're going to knock over the Horde." The statement was absurd. When Alyn scrunched her brow Entrapta realized she had to explain, "Horde rockets can take out our drones now. We're stuck here, alone. The last reports from the Alliance state that the Horde claimed victory over this imagined threat from space. When the comet crashed earlier in the year… I guess Hordak took that to be some kind of signal. He started pressing his borders and hit the capital of the Kingdom of Snows over the course of a few months. From there he pushed into Salineas, While their navy might be impressive, they were outclassed by the troop landings." Entrapta mustered strength to tell the next part,

“After they heard how quickly Salineas fell, Plumeria switched quickly to opening ceasefire negotiations with the Horde. Brightmoon is all that’s left of the resistance.” Entrapta winced a long moment, “Once they’re gone… Hordak isn’t going to need weapons anymore, his victory will be complete.”

Alyn concluded, “And so he won’t need Dryl anymore.”

Before Entrapta could ask, her friend said, “No, I don’t regret staying.”

A kind of admiration came to Entrapta’s expression then. She gestured to the patio furniture for Alyn to take a seat, “I’ll get our drinks.”

Alyn nestled into the padded chair, fingers folded between her knees. She heard Entrapta move into the open plan coffee house. She looked through her browline glasses at the square, only a handful of people would be here all day, fewer were awake at this time of the day. She thought about the all nighter they just pulled. They drifted from topic to topic. The last thing they were talking about before they decided to break for coffee was some kind of advanced medical bed. A very old idea, they were speculating if it was one of the ones on the table when they first met. Twelve years she’s known Entrpata for now. She knew her to be smart but strangely dim when it came to reading people. Alyn had been listening in on Entrapta’s thoughts through her Halo for quite some time now. Entrapta still thought that Alyn was just very good with her powers of deduction even when she answered the most obscure unusual things. She watched the city she’s come to call home lazily rouse itself. Sticks with lingering orange and yellow lone leaves were interrupted by concrete square buildings, still they nodded with the wind letting the last of their leaves go. She breathed some of the crisp mountain air lightly salted with ozone. Her friend had melded easily into the leadership role on the council. She still freshly remembered the day that she broke the council… Why did Entrapta choose her over Warren? It was an objectively bad decision. What if she lead Entrapta down peril's path again? There were times where

she would go into a fugue state, but she couldn't figure out the pattern or what would trigger it.

Up came her hand to touch her lips, clutching her elbow with the other as she relaxed into the chair. She barely touched the padding with her back before Entrapta returned from the shop with two cups.

Alyn asked, knowing Entrapta by now, "What was their special today?"

Entrapta handed over the vanilla chai espresso that Alyn always wanted, "They had some kind of cinnamon honey latte that I couldn't turn down."

Alyn observed, "Seems kinda opulent for us to be enjoying fancy coffee when things are going to be measured by calorie soon."

Entrapta leaned in, "I was actually thinking about that when I was waiting for the coffee. We could take on that problem! There's lots of ways that we could supplement food production. I was thinking-"

Alyn held up a finger interrupting, "I… was actually thinking about a condition for our next project. Just…" *to protect you* , "to try something different."

The engineer tilted her head, "Okay, go on?"

"What if… you gave me the parameters, and then we both worked on the idea separately. You know, to turn it into a competition." Alyn said.

Entrapta tilted her head thinking, ' *but collaborating with you is the best!* ' Entrapta said, "But you love collaborating."

Alyn frowned, it made it harder to say, "Like I said, I just want to try something different. We can collaborate on the next project."

Entrapta thought, ‘ *that sounds terrible* ’ She said, “Well, I do like trying out different ideas… are you sure?”

Alyn felt her throat clutch. *Just until I can figure out what’s triggering me exactly, please Entrapta. Be patient* . Alyn nodded, she forced a smile, “So… we’re going to be supplementing food for this one? I propose we call it project Gemini, since we’re both going to be coming at it from different angles. We can even hold a big event when it’s time to unveil our answers to the problem. We could call it…” Alyn clearly stumped herself trying to figure out what to call the big reveal day. She spied the annoying top of Entrapta’s head, “Pigtail day.” she stifled a chuckle and brought the drink to her lips.

Entrapta smiled but clearly hated the idea, “No! We are not calling it that.”

Alyn laughed outright, “What? There’s two projects, two of us, two of those.”

Entrapta rubbed her temples, “How about Compare and Contrast day?”

Alyn teased snidely, “Doesn’t roll off the tongue like pigtail day.”

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https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nW5vzU5u0Kg

The work

Entrapta looked at the Ares stick. Alyn wasn’t here, she *could* smoke one. Substitution… Entrapta looked around and grabbed the gnarled pencil that she’s been destroying with her teeth. She shook her head, remembering the literal black lung that Alyn had shown her.

“What was I doing…” she muttered. She picked up the voice recorder that had suddenly become very important to her now that Alyn wasn’t around to listen to her talk, “November 18th… 19th?” She looked at the computer, “Stars… 20th, I’m down to ten

days from pig-.... Compare and Contrast day. Prior supplements have been mediocre, the most promising is the polymer extender, the one where we added plastics to food. Remember that? It might cause some problems from extended use down the line but it certainly fills the belly in a satisfying way."

She slid over to project table two where terrariums swarmed with insects, "I think this might be the way forward though. It's unconventional, but insects reproduce at a breakneck rate. Houseflies, cockroaches, and grasshoppers for their taste." She made a face, "with enough spices and re-branding I'm sure that this is going to be everyone's favorite. I even managed to get one of the best chefs in Dryl to work on the project before Alyn scooped her up."

Entrapta's excitement faded, "Side note…" She told the recorder, "It's been very difficult not talking about this with Alyn. I didn't realize how much I've been enjoying having her around. It's… lonely here without her."

Her words echoed back to her in the converted throne room. She stared at the buzzing boxes filled with insect life, their drone harmonized with the tone that seemed to be ever present in Dryl. The woman sat like a knot in her chair, knees close to her chest. She clicked the recorder off, placing it on her chin in thought as she watched the clouds swirl inside the boxes. She told the empty room, "I really have pushed everyone away, haven't I?"

The lab was stone still, nothing moved. Her office window had been shattered by a marble sphere award that laid on the ground. One of the strip lights in her office flickered, struggling to be on. Her chair was turned over, the microscope on its side. There was a picture on her desk turned down. All of the tinctures on her shelves were missing, books were on the ground stacked in a semicircle with different states of being open and unread. Somewhere the sound of something sliding against something sharp echoed. Alyn's voice grunted so far away. All of the cubicles the office looked out over were empty. Some had

personal effects that were hastily put into boxes but still left behind. Closer, that same sound came again. Alyn was in surgery near the cubes, struggling with the task in front of her.

The scalpel ran across the bone exposing the white to the surgery lamp. Eclypse was empty. It had been empty since the first decrees came from the Horde.

"Almost like they wanted to leave." Alyn's delirious voice huffed out while she worked. Her brow was drenched in sweat, she had been doing this for quite some time. Blood, bone, and tripe were in the corner draining into a septic grate on the floor

It was such a simple solution. Entrapta surely wouldn't think of it.

She rotated the carcass. It was literally a new source of nourishment. Why weren't more people doing this?

In went the knife deep into the animal. The sigh of flesh separating from flesh sung from her instrument. Her surgical mask was already dotted with blood, her apron soaked completely. Still she worked in the cold blue light, green eyes wide. She lifted the cut from the beast and plopped it onto the growing pile to her left. Back she went to butchering. Her voice murmured, "Just the muscle… away from the organs…"

Compare and Contrast day

Despite it being the deepest December, almost everyone left in the city made their way to Courtly Commons square. The square itself was normally the heart of Dryl's commercial district. Traveling vendors would come and set up shop in the center of the decorative square just outside the high walls of Dryl's concrete castle, at least before the siege. Patio furniture and snow covered flower beds were nestled around the outside of the twenty five yard clearing. Two styles seemed to fight around this place, the brutal, functional concrete that rose up in the surrounding mostly empty apartments and the cozyness of the historical storefronts

that relied on old organic woods and decorations. Each storefront had cheerful signage indicating the type of shop that it was, from processors to pretzels.

Most of Dryl was there in front of the stage that was set up for a dual presentation from Alyn and Entrapta. They were hungry for an answer to the food shortage that the Horde had imposed on them. Hungry for relief from the siege. They were Hungry. Stage left was decorated in white and grey, the traditional colors of Lyte. It was interrupted by the rich red of the seasoned meat that Alyn had come up with. The other side held Entrapta's traditional purple with red trim that made up Dryl's symbols. Her side had a sizable stack of ration bars each with a printed signature of the chef that Entrapta managed to score.

The two waited behind the curtains. An aide told them, "Most of the city is out there. It's an incredible turn out!"

Entrapta watched Alyn's non-responsive stare. She thought for sure the news would have stoked *something* in her. But she was just watching the slight sway of the curtains.

Entrapta waved her thin hand in front of Alyn's field of vision forcing her out of the trance. "You okay over there?"

Alyn's eyes widened at Entrapta, then moved back to the curtain. Her voice was a fraying song,

"In the realm of gears and belts, I spin like a top,

Surrounded by functionality, my endless whirl won't stop.

One day, a friend emerged, our whirling ways entwined,

She observed my turns, and I watched her grind.

Reforged within the crucible of war's relentless flame,

She grew sharp, embraced by love's tender claim.

While I, altered, lost in my ceaseless spin,

She flourished, resilient in the face of what has been.

Together, we ventured on twin roads of gold,

I stumbled in my spin, she moved forward, bold.

Before hungry beasts, our treasures laid,

Her offerings pure, mine a feast displayed.

Whom would they choose, these gluttonous beasts?

Her ambrosia divine, or my mutton, man-made feast?”

Cold numbness embraced Entrapta’s heart as her friend silenced just watching the curtain again. She reached her hand to touch Alyn’s shoulder, “Hey… when’s the last time you got some sleep?”

All she got was a shadow of Alyn, her green eyes wild and wide. Something about looking at Entrapta made her lips twitch into a smile as she dug her way out of whatever she was suffering, “H-... hey”

Now that she thought she was again with her, Entrapta asked, “Are you going to be okay out there?”

“Y-... yeah.” She said.

“How long were you thinking about that poem?” Entrapta asked.

It made Alyn blush and look down. Before she could say anything else the announcer started to introduce them.

Entrapta tried to lighten the mood as she stood, "Once we're done here, you're going to go on vacation for like a month."

Alyn rose and started to follow the engineer.

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https://youtu.be/ydZhfSH3qQo?si=FEhutHZejtybCcIu&t=35

Entrapta had expected the people to cheer when they saw them emerge from behind the curtain. She had imagined warm welcoming faces. When the curtain produced them they were welcomed with a spattering of almost 10 people clapping for them. Maybe less. What struck her most was the gaunt expression everyone had. Their *eyes.* Their haunting sunken eyes.

She found her voice holding a microphone up to her face, "Welcome to Compare and Contrast day!" Again, the same 10 people sporadically clapped.

"We're here to introduce our solutions to the food shortage problem that we all face!" Entrapta smiled widely, getting ready to sell her solution, "I lost the coin toss back stage so I have to go first." She chuckled but nobody joined her.

"Will there be samples!?" she heard from the crowd.

She tried to give a dry laugh, "Yes, there's going to be a tasting if you'll just wait for us to explain our products to you. You'll be voting with your tongues as to who is going to get to launch a factory line."

A woman shouted, "We're hungry!"

Entrapta gave a showman's smile to that one and said, "Let me begin then." She clicked her presentation wand and a slide came up, "If I may present to you: Flutter Flavors. Crafted from a

special mix of spices and arthropods, these ration bars take part of an ancient cultural practice of entomography. Deep in our history we practiced this, it's in our very genetics to find these ration bars delectable! I managed to tap one of our highest honored chefs to craft several delicious flavors. Sweet mango, Savory tuna and the very snackable Cinnamon Apple these are sure to be the answer to our ongoing difficultie-"

Entrapta stopped as the front of the crowd started to hobble closer to the bottom of the stage.

She pointed, "Now… don't everyone come up at once, there's going to be a line formed after the presen-tation." Hands started to grasp at the lip of the stage, a chorus of demands came up from the human wave growing close. Primal fear started to dig into her, this wasn't going according to the plan at all.

She glanced over at Alyn. The same thing was happening to her side of the stage. She had her hands over her lips, a manic, giddy grin behind them. She drew closer to the grasping human tide and reached out to take hands. Entrapta saw it unfold in slow motion, ten hands wrapped around various parts of Alyn and pulled her in as they all washed across the lip of the stage. Alyn was folded into a mass of writhing grasping limbs while shrieking in laughter. Entrapta's side was next. The hungry people swelled over the edge and rushed to the table near her. She screamed and ran towards where she last saw her friend tossing the microphone to the side causing feedback. Her pigtails shot forward and parted the human sea, "No! Let her go!" she shouted. Somehow she leveraged herself down into the legs of the mob. Somewhere gunfire opened up. Screams were all around but Entrapta had to get to-.

She saw Alyn's limp body. One side of her hair grounded, the other laid out three people flat to make a path to her. Entrapta's knees skidded to a stop next to the bloodied doctor. How did it happen so fast? She scooped Alyn in her arms and lifted them above the crowd with the aid of her purple pigtails. She was just tall enough with the extension that she was able to see the

stage. The table was gone, the meat was gone, just a group of people screaming and tearing at each other for the food. She saw a limp body on the stage staring up at the sky in death. Fights were everywhere, guns were being fired but nobody cared.

They were hungry.

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https://youtu.be/fnMJi1SRLBQ?si=O5oGoNphoz2TplYt&t=17

Later…

It was dark and lonely in the throne room turned office. Entrapta had her hands pressed together bisecting her lips while she looked at the center where the imposing chair had once been. Footsteps were drawing closer. His form was familiar.

"Pull up a chair Warren." Entrapta's hair reached the ten feet to the next project desk's chair.

The man stood, his expression somber. Entrapta just stared back from her seat.

Finally he said, "Nine people dead, sixty injuries."

Entrapta seemed to ignore it. She looked back to the center of the room where her father's chair once was.

He said, "That's not why I'm here though. I'm here because of what was on Alyn's slides."

She thought about how imbalanced she was just before the presentation, her imagination ran wild with the sprawling rambles of writing that she might've made. Disturbing conspiracy scribbles. Warren was going to suggest that she be removed from the council even though he had no authori-

"People…"

She flicked her red eyes to him.

“She fed that crowd people, Entrapta.”

The judgment

They were there in the board room again. Each held a red card up at each other. All eyes were on Entrapta holding up a green card. Her head jostled while tears spilled down her face. She croaked, “Don’t kill my friend.”

When Warren had volunteered to return to the chamber to act as a judge it brought the non returning members back to their seats. The cards indicated whether or not to support the death penalty for Alyndrah for what she did.

Warren pinched at the bridge of his nose. He shook his head and switched to flipping through papers. He lifted another letter and read from it, “I cannot live with myself anymore. Today my daughter was confused as to why we couldn’t have another portion of meat like we got to have on compare and contrast day. She wishes that we could have another because it was so delicious.”

Entrapta grit her teeth enduring it. “She’s just sick. Let’s help her get better.”

Warren shook his head and tossed the letter to the side moving to the next one, “My father died from a Horde gunshot wound for ‘resisting’ about a week ago. We were told that it was a closed casket because of the damages, how do we know that we didn’t end up eating a part of him because of Compare and Contrast day?”

Entrapta’s face creased, defiantly holding her card up still.

Warren leaned forward in his chair, “I have fifty more letters here Entrapta. I demand that you either switch to execution or abstain due to conflict of interest.”

Entrapta looked from face to face. She saw the resolution on each one. There was no win here. There was only…

She said through her clenched throat, "I want to be the one to do it. I'm the one that pushed for her seat on the council, I'm the one that came up with the idea to fix the food problem. It's *my fault* . So let me fix it."

The board members looked at each other murmuring. After a moment Warren gave a solemn nod.

Entrapta's green card went down.

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https://youtu.be/5DNl22MvaNo?si=e4i_ulvYMnwEepEf&t=11

The visit

Entrapta walked with the police force towards Eclypse Labs. She gestured for them to wait at the entrance. Her red eyes watched warily at the hanging open entrance door. Where there was once well polished glass doorways, now hung the shattered frame of doors. Entrapta pressed the push bar, creaking the damaged doorway open. Somewhere water was running. Most of the lights were on in the main archway where the cubicles were. Almost none of the chairs were upright anymore. Entrapta's steel toed boots crunched on glass as she made her way through, almost kicking a spherical award. Her long purple hair gingerly picked it up for her to see. ` *For high marks in psychology* ' it read.

"Alyn!?" Entrapta called to the eerie space of what was her friend's pride and joy.

From Alyn's office she heard a sob-like choking noise. A crash and then a wailing voice said, "No!... No- I'll come to you!"

Entrapta waited a moment, then another before she took footsteps towards the short stairs that led to Alyn's office. The door was closed. She waited there, heard more shuffling and

another soft tumbling of some items. Entrapta called, "I'm at the door, Alyn. Please let me in."

She heard her come close. Stop. A few more steps.

Entrapta's hand came to the door and she quietly begged, "Please open the door Alyn. I'm here to talk with you."

The door latch clicked and it opened. Alyn gave a helpless laugh, "I'm sorry, I don't know what happened here. It's such a mess."

Entrapta glumly asked, "Can I come in?"

"Sure! Sure! Yes, please." Alyn smiled. The doctor was haggard, strands of hair fraying around her Halo ponytail. She was in an open lab coat with a white shirt and tie. She wore a grey skirt and her flat shoes she liked. She moved away from the door and started to right the lounge area. Entrapta's eyes took in the disaster scene that was her office. Nothing was the same, it was a twisted nightmare. All the books were off her shelves and tossed around, the computer desk was turned over, the chair gone from there. Behind the desk the monitor was a struggling light more than anything else. A cross breeze blew from the floor to ceiling oval windows through to the front doorway. Alyn managed to get the lamp and impossibly, a functional air purifier to make a slightly orderly nook for them to sit at.

"Can I get you…" Alyn's expression went distant realizing that everything to make anything edible was broken or missing. "What happened here?" She whispered.

Entrapta sat down and indicated for Alyn to take the other seat, "It's okay, it's okay."

Alyn slowly sat down reading Entrapta like she always did. "I'm… I'm going away now. You've brought people here."

Somehow, she managed to say calmly, "Yeah." Her throat tightened, "It's spooky when you do that."

She squinted at Entrapta, "There's… more too- Oh!... oh…"

Entrapta squinted slightly, did she understand what was coming? She needed to clarify, "They're going to…" *I'm going to…*

Alyn looked at her knees and smoothed out her skirt there. She said, "Yes." She looked at Entrapta, "How do you feel about that?"

Entrapta scoffed, looked up and to the side a great wince coming to her face. Of course Alyn was thinking about her mental state right now instead of her own. Entrapta complained, "Stars… how do you think I feel? I'm *devastated!* I'm so sorry I had no idea how bad things got for you."

A silence nestled. Entrapta started to say, "Alyn, I love-"

Alyn pointed at Entrapta in a split second. She commanded, "No! No, don't you say that now."

Entrapta looked taken aback by the sudden denial. Alyn explained, "You don't love me, you are in a delirious state right now. You are filled with heightened emotions that are trying to romanticize what we had, perhaps cementing or creating something that never was… I looked for it in our time together, it was never there. You always were thinking about the project that we were working on. There was no room for anything else. That's okay, it's what makes you great at what you do. The best I could ever do was be a light next to what mattered to you."

Entrapta's brows crunched. She hated how right Alyn could be sometimes. She asked, "Can't it be true that I may not have before but now I understand that I do?"

Alyn explained, "You might genuinely feel that in this moment, but it won't last. You're only feeling that way now that I'm leaving. I can't leave you every day. I can't bring you to the edge every hour. Exhaustion would claim you in a week. It's just not in you to love, Entrapta. Look what it did to me."

Entrapta's eyes drifted to the madness that was Alyn's office, then back to her.

Alyn soberly watched Entrapta. The engineer looked down at her hands on her knees. They stayed like that for a long moment.

Alyn finally broke the silence, "They're waiting, aren't they?"

Entrapta hissed a breath in and brought the heel of her hand to her watering eyes, "Fuck you Alyn…"

She got up from the comfortable chair and walked to Entrapta. She draped a hand at her neck and pulled her into her navel. The princess broke sobbing into her.

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https://youtu.be/RwJscjiB0Sc?si=Y92ga_G7u5PZIv58

The execution

Her throat clicked, she was past laughing now. In a flash from her mania she slammed into depression. A miserable stutter came from her then. The engine had stopped. Pieces of garbage thumped off the chassis of the wagon that protected them from her, and her from them. The mob was alive hissing and booing at her. All she did was find a perfectly suitable solution for what they were in. She was careful to separate the deadly parts of the bodies. She did it with care, she sterilized it for them. But still they lacked the vision of the dire situation that they all found themselves in. This was it, her last moments of life. Everyone handling her looked calm, as though they did this every day. The door opened. The noise filled the small cage. Her restraints were removed from the seat and she was moved by two strong guards from that environment into Courtly Commons. Snow had fallen, the human cluster had enough heat to melt the ground at their feet. The guard's boots crunched the snow. The place of her doom was built solidly and high above the swelling mob. They must have learned from Compare and Contrast day. Alyn looked over at the angry faces shouting at her. Her expression

frightened, sad. She was mostly hoisted up the stairs to join Warren and Entrapta. Entrapta's face was already wet with tears, trembling at what she was about to do.

She knew she would say it, she thought she had prepared herself against it but she heard herself say, "I'm sorry!" to Entrapta.

She was looking at the execution device when she heard Entrapta respond, "I know, I'm sorry too."

There in the center of the stage a metal black box was bolted to the ground that rose about three and a half feet. On the top flap a gun was welded through. She understood, the box was going to capture the bullet causing it to ricochet and ensure that only a single shot would be needed. If the situation was different, she might even call it genius in its deadly simplicity. Warren was talking to the crowd loudly listing off the violations that she had incurred. She was forced to her knees and her chains locked to the ground.

Alyn's sheer terror looked back at Entrapta. She heard Alyn say, "I don't want to die." before her blonde head was shoved inside. Alyn's arms were secured as well in a gallows. Entrapta heard the crowd rise. All of them hated her friend who was just trying to save them. Warren finished his list saying something about how this is the will of the board of directors and that this was justice.

A numbness rolled over her head looking back to Warren, somehow she wished that Alyn had done more just so that he had more to read. She *had* asked for this. It *was* her responsibility for not keeping track of how damaged she was. Alyn shivered in the restraints. She was torturing her by not being swift and as painless as possible.

It was time. She came to the doctor's side and held the firearm. Alyn struggled underneath but there was no other option. She was doing the will of the people here, merely an extension of their will.

The muzzle flashed inside the black box when Entrapta fired.

The crowd cheered in that second but Entrapta knew something was wrong instantly. Her friend jerked but was not still, a horrific muffled noise belted out from inside. The first shot wasn't enough. She gasped and then quickly fired again, then again. The crowd silenced as she kept pulling the trigger and screamed as loud as she could. The box had dents, but was not destroyed. It was never meant to be waterproof, Alyn's blood drizzled as syrup from the device down onto the snow below the stage.

The next thing she knew she was clicking an empty gun. The hammer clacked over and over to everyone's stunned silence. She realized it was over. Alyn's body was limp in death. Her bloody throat sagged horrifically against the enclosure. Entrapta fell on it weeping, wrapping it in every limb she had.

Someone in the crowd had the nerve to start cheering, the mob joined in clapping and jeering.

Alyn wasn't even cold. Entrapta's red eyes glared fiercely, rising up from trying to comfort the corpse. She teetered dangerously on the edge of the stage seething out at the vengeful faces. Entrapta's lips peeled back as she howled a mournful scream of loss at them. Then another, causing face to turn as red as her eyes, tonight she would lose her voice from this alone. Until then, she screamed hoarsely at them, "Is this enough for you!? Isn't there enough death looming over us all?!!"

The crowd swelled right back at her calling her monster and beast for defending the corpse. Entrapta, shaped her hair into needles and pointed it at the people ready to murder again. She shrieked and was mid leap down into the crowd when guards caught her and pulled her back to the stage. Her throat chords rose as she raged, "Fuck you all! I've given you ***everything*** now! It's not enough!? I will ***kill us all you selfish nothings!!*** "

Warren rushed to the guard's side grabbing at her Halo hair bands tearing one off her head. That side of her hair fell limp but she

ignored it, fury made her writhe and shriek against the human restraints.

https://youtu.be/jMvgX7BJZDw?si=UvVbEnpOaldkd1Hj

She remembered then that she was taken away to the same prison wagon that they had produced Alyn from. The doors were slammed but the crowd swelled around the vehicle. It was minutes before they could drive away from the square to another location. Entrapta numbly let things happen around her, feeling her torso pressed with the turns that the vehicle was taking. Nearby something glinted that caught her attention. A top was rolling back and forth on the seat next to her. She recognized it. It was a large version of the micro gyroscopes that were built to self-charge the beta halo that Alyn had accidentally bonded herself to. Entrapta looked at it confusedly. *Just when did you become so interested in tops?*

Entrapta rubbed her thumb along the golden surface of the contained gyroscope, Alyn's words flit through her mind.

… whatever mattered to you.

The door opened, guards were expecting her to come out. She shivered, she didn't deserve to be anywhere but in prison right now. One of them said, "Princess, you have to get to a safe spot." She pocketed the object into her blood spattered flight suit. She squinted at them, her voice raw and rasping, "Can't I have a goddamn minute? I just killed my best friend."

The guard visibly sneered at her but took a step back.

Months later

Entrapta knocked on the door. She forced herself to do it. She needed to talk with him. She stepped back and adjusted her flight suit around her waist. The springtime air was hot enough so that the tank top was enough to keep her warm. To the doorway came footsteps, then hushed conversation.

She realized that the moment to justify her presence might be fleeting. She said, "Please, I need to talk with Orion, just… just for a little while."

The door to the Starwatcher residence cracked open. A handsome man's face peered through.

A smile tugged at the edge of Entrapta's lips deepening the lines there as well as her eye, "Hey Archer."

"You know you can set up a shrine to honor him in the castle." Orion's son reminded her.

Entrapta looked at her feet, mumbling, "He… It wasn't really his favorite place."

Archer rolled his eyes and retreated from the door. He gave his permission by calling from a distance, "See yourself out when you're done."

She said in an apologetic tone, "I won't be long!" But he didn't respond.

Entrapta pushed the doorway open more and went inside the home of her old friend. She turned to the foyer doing her best to not look anywhere but the corner where a picture of Orion was set. Her twin pigtails held back by the Halo hair bands wagged as she walked over. Tinctures and keepsakes of him were littered across five shelves vertically. A telescope, a sextant, several pieces of carved vindanyte to be shaped like gears along with ten or so pictures. Her first version of the Toolbot was at the bottom, purposefully undusted.

She glumly smiled at the portrait and said, "Hey there old friend…" Her reflection looked back at her, nothing like it was in her youth when she got to know the man. "You probably don't recognize me." She commented, absorbing how much time had passed, "I'm sorry I missed the funeral way back then. It looks like Archer has grown into a fine man… I hope to see him on the council soon, when he feels ready."

The portrait quietly watched her. She went on, "Warren… The council is back to the way it was. I don't talk much there these days. Maybe I finally figured out that if you want to have people hear you, you have to listen first. Maybe if I listened more when she was alive none of this would have happened the way it did. I could've caught that something was wrong sooner."

She guessed that he would ask her about what she was working on, she winced for a beat and then answered, "I haven't really thought about taking on any projects since-... Yeah she would want me to work on something new. Maybe find a new friend. I just don't seem to have any of those anymore."

She silently lamented, then explained, "They won't let me make a shrine to her, they barely let me incinerate her body in the great forges. I guess… I just have to imagine one." Entrapta shifted her weight and brought a hand up to her mouth thinking. "I hope she knows how well she did, hiding all that pain. I never thought of her as suffering."

She watched the picture for a long moment trying to think of anything else she needed to talk about. She said, "Well I did say that I wouldn't be long. Take care Orion."

She let a smile touch her lips again and ran her thumb along the portrait's frame.

Quietly she left the house.

Chapter 17: Editing Notes

3/14/2026 - Lyte Love and Loss still releasing.

Removed all AI generated imagery. Was generated during the onset of the tool and repulses readers instead of attracting them now. Noticed Alyn's poem before her execution, does not add to the story and will be removed later.

More incremental stories to be added surrounding Project Chimera, perhaps one involving Catra and her involvement of gathering intel to launch the Horde's Geneshift program.

Minor tweaks will be added to Early years for clarity, continuity of characters and other minor fixes to be outlined when LLL completes releasing.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!